

Redrawing Democracy: The Geography of Political Representation and England's Great Reform Act

Adriane Fresh*

Duke University

September 1, 2026

Abstract

Democratic reforms are often studied as moments of franchise expansion, but they can also reconstruct the geography through which political voice is represented. This paper examines the construction and consequences of representative geography in England's Great Reform Act of 1832. I assemble new data linking changing constituency boundaries to stable local geographies, pre-reform political conditions, elections, and parliamentary careers. I show that population strongly structured the redistribution of representation, while patronal power shaped the precise form that new political geography took. Geographic reorganization increased electoral competition and sharply reduced the immediate persistence of incumbent MPs. Yet many incumbents later returned, often through different constituencies, especially those with more geographically portable political resources. The findings suggest that democratization can reshape representative institutions and political competition even when elite turnover remains limited.

*Interdisciplinary Data Science Program, Social Science Research Institute; and Department of Political Science; adriane.fresh@duke.edu.

1 Introduction

Democratic reform is usually posed as a question of inclusion: who gets the vote? Classic accounts of political development identify democratization with the incorporation of previously excluded groups, while contemporary political-economy theories ask when incumbent elites are willing or compelled to extend political rights (Lipset 1960; Rueschemeyer, Stephens and Stephens 1992; Geddes 1999; Whitehead 2002; Acemoglu and Robinson 2006; Lizzeri and Persico 2004; Aidt and Franck 2015; Cox, Fresh and Saiegh 2023). Even important critiques of a simple inclusionary model have principally reconsidered *which people* democratic reform incorporates. Bateman (2018), for example, shows that democratization is also a process of exclusion and “people-making,” in which political actors construct the electorate the new regime will represent. This paper argues that democratic reform contains another constitutive choice: political voice must also be organized geographically. Representative institutions determine not only who participates, but which populations are represented together and how much representative weight different places receive (Rehfeld 2005; Beramendi 2012). Democratization can therefore construct both the electorate and the geography through which that electorate becomes politically represented.

A large literature on redistricting and gerrymandering establishes that this geography is politically constructed and consequential. Alternative district maps can protect incumbents, advantage parties, alter candidate incentives, and change electoral outcomes, while the underlying spatial distribution of populations constrains what mapmakers can accomplish (Cain 1984, 1985; Cox and Katz 2002; Chen and Rodden 2013; Engstrom 2013; calvo and Rodden 2015; McGhee 2020). But the canonical redistricting problem generally begins after the basic architecture of representation has been fixed: a specified number of seats exists and the problem is how their boundaries should be drawn. Democratic transitions can present a logically prior problem. Political actors may be deciding not simply *where to draw lines*, but which places should possess representation at all, how much representation they should receive, and which populations should be joined within the same representative unit.¹

I study this problem in England’s Great Reform Act of 1832. The Act is conventionally treated as Britain’s first major nineteenth-century franchise reform and has become a canonical case for theories of democratization (Seymour 1970; Acemoglu and Robinson 2000; Aidt and Franck 2015, 2019; Cox, Fresh and Saiegh 2023). Yet franchise reform

¹Gerrymandering is therefore a useful analogue but too narrow a description of the phenomenon studied here. Strategic boundary manipulation is one form of endogenous electoral geography; the Great Reform Act additionally allowed political actors to create and abolish constituencies, change district magnitude, divide counties, and determine whether existing boroughs should survive through geographic enlargement.

was only one part of the settlement. The Act also removed representation from small boroughs, created constituencies for previously unrepresented towns, redistributed seats toward counties, divided counties into new electoral units, and redrew the boundaries of many surviving constituencies (Evans 1994; Spychal 2024). These choices occurred in a society transformed by industrialization and population growth but before anything resembling one-person-one-vote, and in a political system where patronage, landed influence, local reputation, and only partially developed party organizations remained important sources of political power (Gash 1953; O’Gorman 1989).

The case therefore makes visible a political problem that modern redistricting institutions partially suppress. Population provided a powerful claim for redistribution. This is because by 1831 some ancient boroughs retained parliamentary representation despite tiny populations, while Manchester, Birmingham, Leeds, and other major centers of industrial growth lacked independent representation (Seymour 1970; Law 1967; Lees and Lees 2007). But population did not mechanically determine what should replace the inherited map. Reformers still had to prioritize population as a principle of reform, and then decide whether an existing constituency should disappear or instead survive by incorporating surrounding territory, whether growing populations should receive new representation or remain within county constituencies, and how geographic and franchise reform should operate together. Those choices created opportunities for established political interests to shape the *form* of reform even where they could no longer plausibly preserve the status quo.

In this paper, I ask two linked questions. First, how was political representation actually reallocated across space? I examine whether population and economic geography structured the broad distribution of gains and losses and whether popular pressure, existing patronal power, and factional alignments help explain the particular institutional form reform took. Second, what happened to politics once representative geography changed? I examine whether geographic disruption altered electoral competition and whether incumbent MPs were displaced, preserved, or able to adapt by reconstructing their political careers elsewhere.

I answer these questions by reconstructing England’s parliamentary geography before and after 1832. I digitize archival constituency maps produced through the Drummond Boundary Commission and overlay them on stable parish units that can be followed through a reform in which constituencies themselves were created, destroyed, and redrawn. I combine these geographic data with historical census and occupational information, measures of reform pressure and pre-reform political control, constituency election histories, and individual-level parliamentary records that allow me to follow MPs through the institutional transition. This design treats the electoral map first as an outcome to be

explained and subsequently as part of the political environment within which candidates and incumbents operated.²

Three findings stand out. First, demographic conditions strongly structured the new representative geography, but did not exhaust its politics. More populous places were much more likely to experience improvements in representation, consistent with the population-based rationale that reformers publicly invoked. Yet among constituencies confronting reform, pre-existing political characteristics help predict *how* accommodation occurred. Patronal power did not simply protect constituencies from change; it is associated with forms of reform that preserved and adapted existing representative units rather than with a uniform ability to avoid reform. The resulting map was therefore neither a mechanical implementation of population nor straightforward incumbent capture. Political power operated importantly through the choice among alternative forms of change.

Second, geographic reorganization altered the political environment that followed. Places experiencing meaningful changes in representation became more electorally competitive after reform than places whose representative environments changed little. Strikingly, competition increased among places experiencing both improvements and deteriorations in representation. The pattern therefore does not look like a simple consequence of obtaining more parliamentary voice. Instead, it is consistent with geographic reorganization disrupting established political claims and making electoral office newly contestable. This result parallels evidence that later franchise extension increased electoral competition (?), but identifies a different institutional channel through which democratic reform could unsettle established electoral arrangements.

Third, disruption of existing political arrangements did not imply wholesale replacement of the politicians who inhabited them. MPs whose representative environments were most severely disrupted were markedly less likely to persist immediately after reform, and competition in the new electoral environment is associated with lower incumbent survival. The effect was especially stark when constituencies disappeared altogether. Yet many incumbents subsequently returned, often representing entirely different places. Among MPs exposed to abolition, prior experience obtaining representation across multiple counties strongly predicts their ability to return. The evidence therefore distinguishes persistence of an elite from persistence of the institutional basis of its power: politicians with sufficiently portable resources could survive the destruction of the geographic arrangements on which their earlier careers had rested.

²Because the Act simultaneously altered the franchise and representative geography, I do not interpret geographic change as an independently randomized treatment. The analyses instead exploit variation in the degree and form of geographic disruption within the common national reform while directly examining the political processes that selected places into different forms of reorganization.

These findings first extend research on the politics and consequences of democratization. Existing work explains why elites accept or resist reform and, in the British case, how unrest, political agitation, and political expedience affected support for the Great Reform Act (Aidt and Franck 2015, 2019, 2025). Cox, Fresh and Saiegh (2023) place the reform in a broader state-building process: they argue that reducing the electoral influence of the Crown and allied patronal peers helped constrain the executive, making subsequent investments in state capacity—most notably professional policing—politically feasible. This paper’s results speak directly to that process. Patronal influence was not simply an obstacle that reform either preserved or eliminated; it also shaped the institutional form through which representative geography was reconstructed. Patron-controlled constituencies were more likely to be altered in some ways than others, suggesting that the effort to constrain established political influence was itself mediated by the interests being constrained.

Second, the paper extends research on endogenous electoral geography beyond the canonical gerrymandering setting. Redistricting scholarship demonstrates that politicians care about maps and that maps affect incumbent security, candidate entry, partisan advantage, and political outcomes (Cain 1985; Cox and Katz 2002; Engstrom 2013; McGhee 2020). I study a setting in which the politically endogenous choice set is broader. Reformers could alter not just the boundaries separating represented populations but the existence, magnitude, and relative weight of representative units themselves. The Great Reform Act therefore reveals gerrymandering as one member of a more general class of problems concerning the political construction of representative geography.

Finally, the paper contributes to broader research on elite persistence under institutional change. Existing accounts emphasize that democratization need not displace incumbent elites (Acemoglu and Robinson 2008; Albertus and Menaldo 2018; Ziblatt 2017). Historical work on Britain poses a closely related puzzle: despite successive reforms to representative institutions, the social and political elite represented in Parliament proved remarkably durable (Laski 1928; Berlinski, Dewan and Coppenolle 2014). The evidence here helps distinguish preservation from adaptation as sources of that continuity. Geographic reform sometimes eliminated the institutional base on which an incumbent’s existing parliamentary position rested, yet many such politicians subsequently reconstructed careers elsewhere, with persistence greatest among those whose prior careers revealed geographically portable political resources. Elite continuity therefore need not imply continuity in the institutions or advantages that originally sustained an elite. Disruptive reform can instead change the conditions under which political power must be reproduced, advantaging actors whose resources remain useful when the institutional environment around them changes.

2 The History of Constituency Reform in the Great Reform Act

By 1831, calls for reforming the political environment of England had been building for decades, and the geography of parliamentary representation had become a key part of it. Rapid demographic and economic change collided with an inherited electoral map whose allocation of representation had long been the subject of disputes over population, political influence, and the representation of interests.

2.1 Demographic Change, Interests, and the Road to Reform

By the early nineteenth century, the territorial organization of parliamentary representation in Britain increasingly reflected a demographic and economic geography that no longer existed. Constituencies had accumulated over centuries rather than being periodically reapportioned according to population. Small boroughs therefore continued to return members to Parliament while rapidly growing industrial towns possessed no independent representation and were represented only indirectly through the counties in which they were located (Seymour 1970; Porritt 1903).³

The Population Revolution and Industrial Revolution made these inherited inequalities increasingly conspicuous. By 1831, population and economic activity had become concentrated not only in London and older commercial centers, but in the rapidly expanding industrial districts of Lancashire, Yorkshire, and the West Midlands. Figure 1 shows both the uneven distribution of population on the eve of reform and how recently much of that geography had emerged. Population density increased dramatically in many urban and industrial districts between 1801 and 1831, even as other parts of the country grew slowly or lost population. The resulting mismatch between population and parliamentary representation was dramatic. Old Sarum, the canonical example, retained two members despite barely possessing a resident population; Liverpool returned the same number from a constituency containing approximately 170,000 people; Manchester and Birmingham possessed no independent parliamentary representation at all.⁴

Yet population alone does not explain why this geography became politically contentious.

³Britain's electoral map had never approximated a system of one-person, one-vote, nor had population ever provided the sole rationale for parliamentary representation. Newark-on-Trent, for example, was the last English borough enfranchised by royal writ, in 1673. It was an economically important and growing town, but also a former royalist stronghold that Charles II sought to reward (Edie 1970).

⁴Thomas Paine famously asked of the contrast between Old Sarum and Manchester: "Is there any principle in these things?" (Paine 1984). The problem was not confined to notorious "rotten boroughs": population represented per constituency and per MP varied enormously across the unreformed system; see Figure 5.

Figure 1: The distribution of parish population density, England and Wales



Notes: The above maps present deciles of population density in 1831 (left plot) and the percentage change in population density between 1801 and 1831 (right plot). The units are parishes, and the population data comes from decennial census data (Shaw-Taylor et al. 2015). Shading is uses separate scales for each map.

The irregularity of the unreformed map had long been defended, at least partly, on the grounds that Parliament represented the nation’s varied *interests*—landed and agricultural, commercial and manufacturing, the professions, the Crown, and others—rather than populations in proportion to their numbers (Brock 1973; Clark 1985; Spsychal 2024). By the 1820s, however, Britain’s changing economic geography increasingly unsettled that balance. Manufacturing and commercial interests had grown enormously and were geographically concentrated, while small boroughs remained important channels of landed, aristocratic, and government influence. The problem was therefore not simply that some places contained too many or too few people per MP, but that the inherited geography appeared increasingly to give the *wrong places and interests* differential access to parliamentary power.

Parliament had, moreover, already begun experimenting with geography as a remedy for defects in representation. New Shoreham, Cricklade, and Aylesbury had their electorates extended into surrounding territory, while later controversies over Grampound, Penryn, and East Retford raised a difficult choice—when an existing borough could no longer be defended, should it be preserved by incorporating surrounding populations, or should its representation be removed and transferred elsewhere? These alternatives were contemporaneously understood to redistribute political influence differently. Enlargement could preserve and augment landed or agricultural representation; transferring seats could in-

stead recognize growing manufacturing and commercial towns (Spychal 2024).⁵

These disputes established, before 1832, what we can think of as an institutional *repertoire* for geographic reform. A constituency could disappear, its seats could be moved elsewhere, or its boundaries could be changed so that a different population participated in its representation. In essence, geography was already understood as an instrument through which political representation—and the interests represented in Parliament—could be reorganized, something that could occur without necessarily altering the franchise itself.

At the same time, popular mobilization made parliamentary reform increasingly difficult for governing elites to avoid. Agitation intensified after the Napoleonic wars and again amid the political and economic crises surrounding 1830 (Aidt and Franck 2015, 2025). Elites remained deeply divided over whether reform was desirable and how far it should extend (Evans 1994; Acemoglu and Robinson 2000, 2006; Aidt and Franck 2019; Cox, Fresh and Saiegh 2023), but growing numbers concluded that controlled reform was preferable to continued instability or the possibility that delay would produce something more radical (Gash 1953; Aidt and Franck 2025). The fall of Wellington’s government in November 1830 and the formation of Earl Grey’s ministry transformed these longstanding disputes into the immediate problem of designing a reformed representative system.

Geographic redistribution occupied a central place in that design. Introducing the government’s proposal, Lord John Russell argued that parliamentary representation had “ceased to correspond with the property, population, and intelligence of the country.” Population thus mattered, but as one component of a broader judgment about *which communities and interests merited representation*. Reformers proposed to remove representation from small boroughs, recognize important unrepresented towns, increase representation in growing counties, and reconstruct existing constituency boundaries. Reform therefore concerned not simply *who* would possess the vote—its best-known and best-studied dimension—but *where* political representation would be located and which populations would be assembled within representative units.⁶

There was, of course, nothing close to agreement over what the new geography should look like. Population and economic growth supplied powerful claims for redistribution,

⁵The East Retford controversy made the distributive stakes unusually explicit. In 1828, the Wellington ministry supported transferring Penryn’s representation to Manchester while enlarging East Retford into the surrounding Hundred of Bassetlaw—a compromise intended to accommodate both manufacturing and agricultural claims that subsequently became entangled with cabinet and partisan conflict (Spychal 2024).

⁶This emphasis is also visible systematically in parliamentary debate. In a random sample of 500 sentences from Hansard’s reform debates, I find that geographic representation is the most frequently coded substantive topic, substantially exceeding direct discussion of franchise qualifications. Nearly half of substantive discussion concerns either representative geography or political influence exercised through the existing electoral system. See Appendix B.

but contemporaries disagreed about *how* those claims should be balanced against other interests. Nor could geography be considered independently of the franchise. Changing a boundary changed not only the territory represented, but potentially the electorate within it. Against this backdrop was produced one of the most unusual institutional innovations of the reform process—the Boundary Commission.

2.2 The Boundary Commission and the Re-drawing of the Electoral Map

Translating the principles of reform, once chosen, into an electoral map posed a problem Parliament had never confronted at anything approaching the scale that reform posed. Existing borough boundaries were often ancient and poorly documented, and it was unclear which populations the reformed constituencies would actually contain. The central institution charged with resolving these problems was the English and Welsh Boundary Commission, established in 1831 under Thomas Drummond. Ministers determined the broad principles of reform while delegating geographic implementation to Drummond and a body of technocrats charged with translating demographic and spatial information into new territorial units of representation (Spychal 2024).⁷

The commissioners reconstructed existing borough limits and collected standardized information about their surroundings using, among other information, the relatively novel census data of the age (Levitan 2011).⁸ In many places their work produced the first systematic maps of borough towns themselves. Drummond sought to make these investigations as uniform as England’s irregular local geography permitted and, importantly, commissioners were generally instructed to collect local *information* rather than local *preferences* over where boundaries should fall (Spychal 2024).⁹

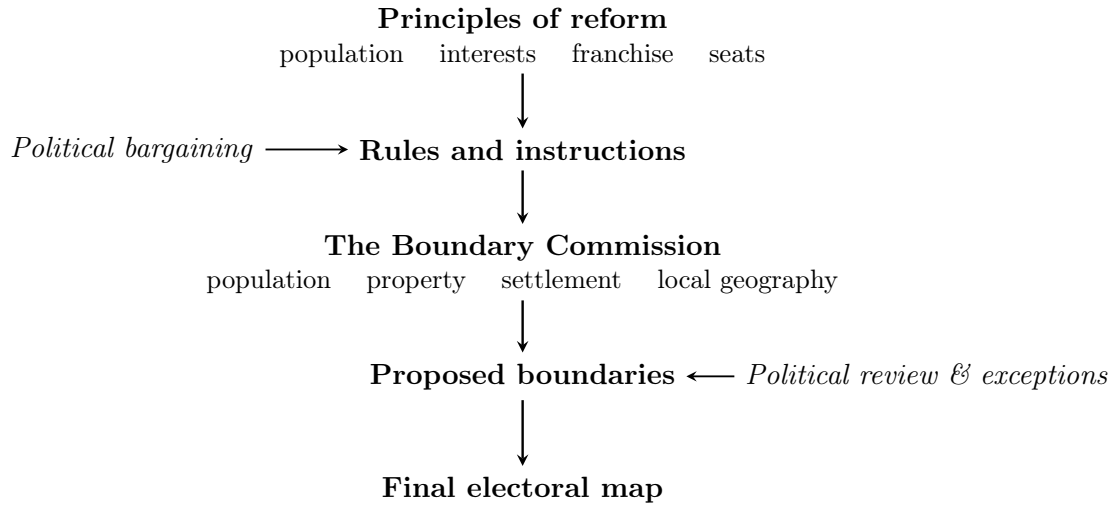
This administrative insulation did not, however, make the resulting geography independent of politics. The commission operated within rules established by political actors; ministers could revise those rules; ministers retained authority over how the information

⁷The commission occupied an unusual legal position. Its preliminary work began under Home Office authority before Parliament had enacted the legislation that would ultimately give the resulting boundaries legal force. Earlier proposals contemplated much more direct ministerial control over boundary drawing, prompting objections that the government would possess opportunities to manipulate the electoral map for partisan purposes (Spychal 2024).

⁸Included information on population, housing and property—including £10 householders—roads and administrative boundaries, and the economic and social relationships between towns and neighboring settlements.

⁹The was deliberate. William Ord argued that commissioners should preserve both “the appearance as well as the reality of judging [future boundaries] for ourselves,” rather than invite local interests to negotiate the lines directly. Drummond similarly insisted in one dispute that the commissioners had “no business in our present work with politics” (Spychal 2024, 117).

Figure 2: The production of constituency geography under the Great Reform Act



generated by the commission would enter the reform settlement; a committee reviewed local recommendations; and Parliament ultimately enacted the boundaries. Political influence could therefore enter at several stages (Figure 2).

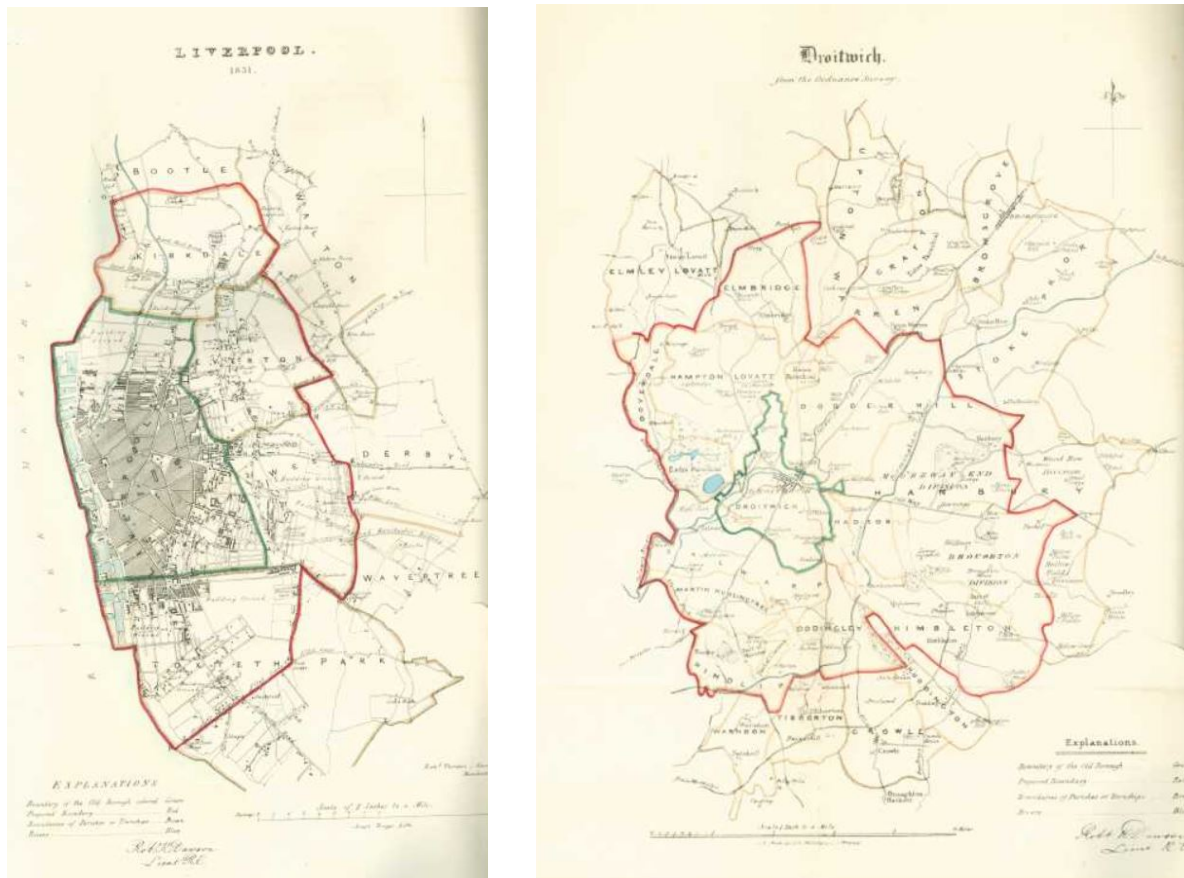
The most consequential example of the politics of the boundaries came in December 1831. Faced with small boroughs that would contain too few voters under the proposed £10 franchise, commissioners had initially considered grouping some with neighboring towns. Ministers instead adopted a new rule allowing vulnerable boroughs to be *enlarged* into surrounding parishes until they contained a sufficient electorate.¹⁰ Commissioners were sent back to revisit and redraw numerous constituencies, producing the unusually extensive “multiple parish” boroughs, a distinctive feature of the final settlement (Spychal 2024).¹¹

Figure 3 illustrates both the geographic changes this process produced and the archival material from which I reconstruct them. Liverpool was extended to encompass what commissioners understood to be the “modern town,” bringing its formal constituency into correspondence with an urban settlement that had expanded far beyond its inherited limits. Droitwich instead incorporated surrounding parishes in order to preserve an existing

¹⁰In February of 1831, 87 boroughs were identified that were expected to contain fewer than the, at-the-time required, principal of 300 householders. Broadly these boroughs were intended to survive, but needed to be made viable.

¹¹The episode also illustrates the interaction between geographic and franchise reform. Which boundary was politically desirable depended partly upon which voters the franchise would create inside it. In a separate discussion of Coventry, Littleton explicitly asked whether it would be “prudent to take manufacturing influence . . . out of the counties” depending upon whether the relevant county franchise survived in the bill (Spychal 2024, 188).

Figure 3: New constituency boundaries drawn by the boundary commission, examples of Liverpool and Droitwich



Sources: The National Archives T 72.

Notes: Two example maps of the constituency boundary changes produced by the Boundary Commission in 1831. The green lines represent the old constituency boundaries, while the red lines represent the newly proposed boundaries. The maps also include major roads, buildings, parish and other major geographic boundaries and historical features. For many boroughs, the maps represented the first true survey of the town. Liverpool represents a constituency whose boundary was extended to the modern town as the city had grown. Droitwich, by contrast, had its boundary extended to encompass neighboring parishes, allowing the existing borough to operate under the new franchise while preserving its representation.

borough within the new representative *and* franchise arrangements.¹² The Commission's surviving maps record old and proposed boundaries alongside roads, buildings, parishes, and other geographic features. They provide the archival basis for reconstructing and digitizing the constituency geographies used in the analysis below.

Boundary revision operated alongside the redistribution of parliamentary seats themselves. The legislation classified boroughs into schedules governing proposed changes (Table 1). Population provided a conspicuously rule-bound element of this process, although the criteria evolved during the reform struggle and ultimately incorporated information

¹²This second strategy had important precedents. Before 1832, Parliament had expanded the boundaries of New Shoreham, Cricklade, Aylesbury, and East Retford in response to corruption and political influence, demonstrating that geographic enlargement could serve as an alternative to complete disfranchisement by altering the population and electorate attached to an existing representative unit (Spychal 2024).

Table 1: Enfranchisement and disenfranchisement schedules for boroughs in the 1832 Reform Act

Schedule	Population Criterion	Number of Boroughs	Seats Changed	Description
Schedule A	Under 2,000 inhabitants	56	removed 111	Boroughs deemed too small to retain independent representation.
Schedule B	2,000–4,000 inhabitants	30	removed 30	Boroughs retained representation but lost one of their two seats.
Schedule C	Above 40,000 inhabitants	22	added 44	Large unrepresented towns/cities given two seats each.
Schedule D	10,000–40,000 inhabitants	20	added 20	Smaller unrepresented towns given one seat each.

Notes: Concerns borough constituencies only, not counties. Schedule A and Schedule B refer to the disfranchisement provisions of the English and Welsh Reform Act. Schedules C and D refer to enfranchisement provisions. The population thresholds provided an apparently rule-bound basis for disfranchisement, but, as Spychal (2024) emphasizes, the reform settlement was not reducible to these schedules alone: boundary revision, parish inclusion, local investigation, and political negotiation also shaped which places retained, lost, or gained representation.

beyond a simple population count (Thompson 2011; Robson 2014; Spychal 2024). Crucially, however, the schedules did not exhaust geographic reform—a constituency could retain its seats while undergoing substantial territorial reconstruction, and apparently similar changes in the number of MPs could bring very different populations into the resultant constituencies.

2.3 The Great Reform Act

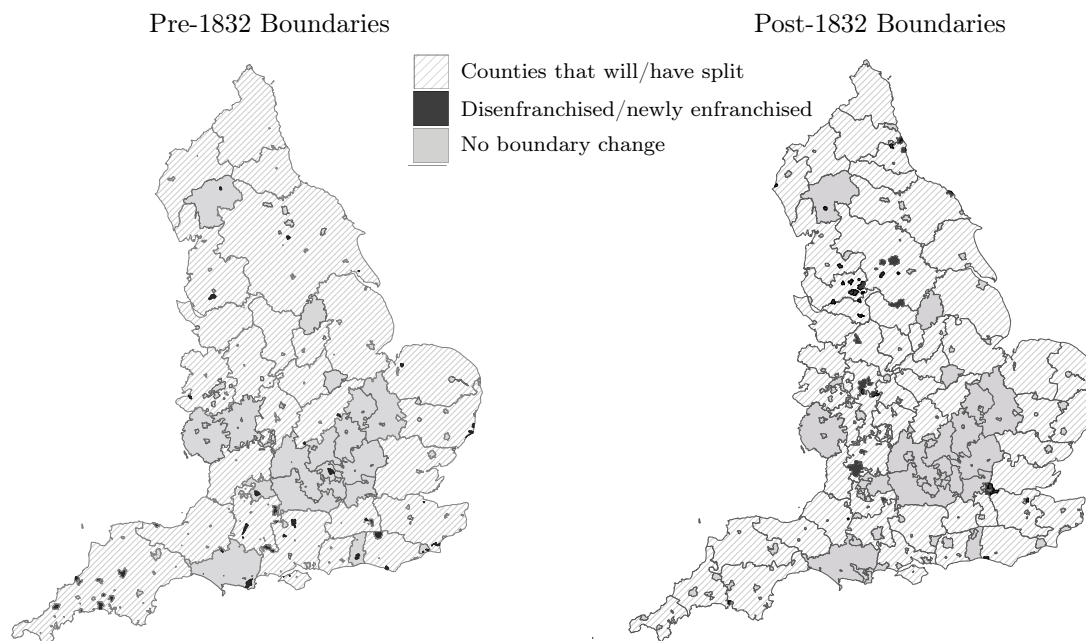
The settlement ultimately enacted in 1832 changed several dimensions of political representation simultaneously. Most famously, the Reform Act reorganized the franchise, establishing a uniform £10 householder qualification in the boroughs while expanding and standardizing qualifications in the counties. The resulting electorate was larger but remained highly restricted.¹³ This reflecting reformers’ efforts to incorporate a predominantly propertied and middle-class electorate rather than anything approaching universal male suffrage (Seymour 1970; Bateman 2018).¹⁴

At the same time, reform redistributed parliamentary representation across space. Small boroughs were disfranchised or lost seats; previously unrepresented towns received MPs; counties gained representation and were subdivided; and the boundaries of many existing

¹³The electorate increased from approximately 400,000 to 650,000 individuals, still less than 5% of the population (Appendix C).

¹⁴The reform did not simply extend an existing franchise downward. Some older voting rights were restricted or allowed to disappear even as new groups were enfranchised. As Lord Grey privately reassured the king, the new right of voting would, “taken generally, be found much less popular than the old one” (Bateman 2018, 255).

Figure 4: Constituency boundaries before and after 1832, England and Wales



Notes: The above maps provide two different ways of visualizing the changes to the constituency boundaries that occurred at the 1832 Reform Act. The left-hand map shows the boundaries of constituencies on the eve of reform as established by the Boundary Commission. Many of these boundaries had existed for centuries, others had only been rough approximations, and a few others—for instance, East Retford—had recently been changed. Striped shading indicates constituencies that that split. Dark gray on the pre-1832 map were disenfranchised; dark gray on the post-1832 map were newly enfranchised. Light gray constituencies kept their same boundaries, recognizing that they still might have experienced the disenfranchisement or enfranchisement of boroughs within their boundaries. Changes in representation alone are not included on the map.

constituencies were reconstructed. Figure 4 shows the resulting transformation.¹⁵ The post-reform system was therefore not simply the old electoral map populated by a somewhat larger electorate. Reform changed both *who* could participate and the geographic units through which that participation was translated into parliamentary representation.

This history raises the two questions that organize the theoretical work of the next section—what broadly explains how political representation was reallocated across space, and what political consequences are to be expected of the new representative geography?

3 The Political Economy of Representative Geography

The starting point for theorizing geographic reform is straightforward—electoral boundaries are politically valuable because politicians care about the constituencies in which

¹⁵Fifty-six small boroughs lost their representation entirely and thirty-one others experienced reductions in their number of MPs. Forty-one new parliamentary boroughs were created, while 00 counties received additional representation and twenty-eight were divided into separate electoral districts. gained additional geography. Examples include: Westbury expanded 1,648-fold, Woodstock 482-fold, Reigate 83-fold, and Morpeth 54-fold. Thirty of the boroughs losing representation were reduced from two MPs to one, while one four-member constituency was reduced to two. Eight English counties received an additional MP without being divided. The City of London retained its four members. See Appendix A.

they and their competitors must seek office. Alternative ways of aggregating populations into districts can generate different distributions of political power even with the same underlying preferences of voters. Parties and incumbents therefore have preferences over alternative maps and, where they possess influence over redistricting, incentives to favor arrangements that improve their expected political position (Cain 1984; Cox and Katz 2002; Engstrom 2013; McGhee 2020). This insight lies at the heart of the large literature on partisan gerrymandering.

The canonical gerrymandering problem, however, takes much of the structure of representative government as given. Parties are established, for instance, and prior elections make the geographic distribution of political preferences legible. Contemporary redistricting also generally constrains the relative representational weight assigned to places. In the United States, “one person, one vote” requires districts to contain approximately equal populations (Cox and Katz 2002; McGhee 2020). Modern British Boundary Commissions similarly operate under statutory rules governing both the number of constituencies and the permissible size of their electorates.¹⁶ Modern mapmakers therefore possess meaningful discretion over *which* populations are represented together, but substantially less discretion over the relative representational weight assigned to them. Even within these constraints, redistricting can affect incumbent and candidate behavior, electoral competition, and partisan advantage (Baseheart and Comer 1991; Cox and Katz 2002; Desposato and Petrocick 2003; Carson and Crespin 2004).

Geographic reform during an incomplete democratic transition presents a related but more expansive problem. Where no principle of equal population (yet) constrains representation, reformers can alter both the *composition* of representative units—which populations are represented together—and their *representational weight*—how much parliamentary representation those populations receive. Political interests may also be less collapsible into party. Where parties remain incompletely developed, claims to representation can attach instead to individual incumbents, patrons, families, the Crown, or elite influence of another form. An incumbent’s political security may likewise rest on geographically embedded resources—e.g., property, social status, or patronage—rather than principally on partisan attachment (Gash 1953; Hanham 1959; Moore 1976; Perkin 1985; O’Gorman 1989).

The underlying strategic problem nevertheless remains recognizable. Political actors should prefer geographic arrangements that preserve or improve their expected access to office and political influence, but they make those choices subject to the various constraints of reform. The geographic component of democratization therefore expands both the set of distributive choices available to political actors, and the way that politics be-

¹⁶Going back to the Parliamentary Constituencies Act of 1986.

comes implicated. The theory below asks first how those interests should shape the reallocation of representative geography, and then second how the resulting geography should alter electoral competition and the persistence of existing elites.

3.1 Constructing Representative Geography

Consider first the construction of the map itself. Geographic reformers do not choose among an unlimited set of territorial arrangements. Existing demographic and economic geography constrains what maps can plausibly be drawn. Modern redistricting research makes a related point—the spatial distribution of political preferences can itself generate representational advantage, even absent intentional gerrymandering, because mapmakers must construct districts from populations already distributed unevenly across space (Chen and Rodden 2013; Calvo and Rodden 2015). Geographic institutions are therefore endogenous to political choice without being infinitely malleable.

Within this constrained choice set, I assume political actors possess preferences over both *i)* the principles governing representation, and *ii)* their own position within the resulting system. Some may favor representation that more closely reflects population, economic vitality, or “meaningful communities”; others may regard historically constituted communities as legitimate sources of geographic representation. At the same time, incumbents and patrons prefer arrangements that preserve access to office and political influence, while actors connected through emerging partisan, governmental, familial, or factional relationships may prefer arrangements that strengthen allies or weaken opponents. “Principle” and “self-interest” are therefore not mutually exclusive motives, but two sources of preferences over alternative representative arrangements.

Those preferences are exercised in a political environment that changes the costs and consequences of alternative maps. Demographic change or popular mobilization, for instance, can make continued denial of representation to a place increasingly costly. But it’s unlikely to mechanically determine what precise type of reform it receives. The franchise is particularly important because geographic and franchise reform are distinct but interdependent institutional choices for actors. The of placing a population inside a constituency depend upon which members of that population can vote, while the consequences of a franchise rule depend upon the populations contained within the boundaries to which it applies.

The way preferences operated historically though was not as the solution to a single actor’s optimization problem. Reform instead emerged through bargaining among actors with preferences over a broader institutional settlement. Losses on one geographic margin could potentially be offset by gains elsewhere—through another constituency, the franchise, or

Table 2: Empirical expectations about the reallocation of geographic representation

Dimension	Observable characteristics	Expectation
Demographic claim	Population; population growth; economic vitality	Larger, growing, and economically expanding places should receive more favorable representation; small, stagnant, and declining places should be more likely to experience worsening representation.
Popular pressure	Reform petitions	Conditional on demographic circumstances, greater local pressure for reform should increase the likelihood improved representation rather than worsening or preservation of the status quo.
Incumbent political power	Patronal control; incumbent political and elite connections	Among constituencies facing similar demographic pressure, greater incumbent political power should increase the likelihood that existing representation is preserved or adapted rather than eliminated.
Factional interest	Political alignment of incumbent MPs	Conditional on demographic circumstances, constituencies represented by actors politically aligned with those directing reform may receive more favorable or accommodating forms of representational change.
Prior political closure	Pre-reform electoral competition; uncontested elections	Conditional on demographic circumstances, constituencies historically insulated from electoral challenge should experience greater geographic disruption if reform targeted existing systems of political control.

Notes: The predictions distinguish the underlying pressures for representational change from political influence over the specific form that change takes. Demographic and economic characteristics capture the representational claims confronting reformers. Popular pressure affects the political cost of leaving those claims unresolved. Importantly, political predictions are conditional. Among constituencies facing similar underlying pressures for reform, incumbent political resources and political alignment should help explain whether existing representative arrangements are eliminated, preserved, or adapted.

another component of the political bargain. Political influence should therefore improve an actor’s expected position in the settlement without necessarily preserving any particular constituency. Moreover, as the history of the previous section demonstrates, delegation to the Boundary Commission limited some forms of direct bargaining over individual lines while leaving political actors considerable influence over the rules under which those lines were drawn and opportunities to seek particular exceptions. These arguments generate the expectations summarized in Table 2.

Population. The first concerns population, one of the central representational principles through which reform was justified. If that principle meaningfully constrained the reform, larger and growing places should receive greater representation, while smaller and stagnant places should be more vulnerable to losing it.¹⁷ A weak relationship would itself be revealing, indicating a substantial gap between the demographic logic invoked to justify reform and the geography actually enacted.

Population, however, presents an interpretive complication. Reallocating representation toward populous and growing places need not reflect *only* an abstract principle of representational fairness. Political actors may also anticipate that the populations or elites of growing places will favor particular political interests. The same allocation can therefore be consistent with principled *and, or* strategic motivations. The empirical analysis can establish whether population systematically structured the allocation of representation; population alone cannot establish *why* political actors preferred that allocation.¹⁸

Popular Pressure. Popular pressure provides a second test. Existing theories of democratization give protest and the threat of disorder an important role in explaining why incumbent elites concede reform *overall* (Acemoglu and Robinson 2000; Aidt and Franck 2015). It does not follow necessarily, however, that the places generating those pressures should themselves benefit geographically from the resulting settlement.¹⁹ Mobilization might make reform necessary nationally while leaving its geographic allocation to other forces; alternatively, local petitions and protest may raise the political cost of leaving particular representational grievances unresolved. Conditional on similar demographic circumstances, whether mobilized places receive more favorable geographic treatment therefore tells us something about whether popular pressure helped produce reform only, or also shaped the distribution of its benefits.

Incumbent Political Power. The political power of existing elites provides a third, and potentially competing, account. Geographic reform threatened political assets attached to particular representative units, giving incumbents and patrons incentives to preserve their position where possible. The relevant prediction is explicitly conditional: among constituencies facing comparable demographic pressures, those attached to more politically powerful incumbents or patrons should be more likely to secure preservation or adaptation rather than elimination. The question is therefore not simply whether es-

¹⁷Importantly, receiving representation is akin to an “improvement” in the MP per population ratio, the measure that I employ later on. This could come from receiving more MPs (boundary change equal); experiencing a reduction in the area of the constituency (MP allocation equal); or some combination of the two.

¹⁸The test would be... XX.

¹⁹Put differently, threat theories of democratization generally emphasize the extensive margin of reform rather than its intensive margin—the particular franchise, geographic allocation, or other institutional rules that reform produces.

tablished elites could prevent reform, but whether political power allowed them to shape the institutional form through which they experienced it.

Factional Alignment. Factional alignment asks whether geographic discretion was also used to favor political allies. The party system of 1832 was far less developed, and political preferences less legible, than in modern gerrymandering settings (Cox 2005; Dewan, Merilainen and Tukiainen 2020). Reformers could nevertheless distinguish allies from opponents and anticipate at least some consequences of alternative allocations. Conditional on demographic circumstances, systematically more favorable treatment of constituencies represented by political allies would therefore suggest a proto-partisan component to geographic reform. A null relationship would be equally informative: despite the stakes and discretion involved, the settlement would show little evidence of systematic factional favoritism.

Prior Electoral Competition/Closure. Finally, prior electoral competition provides an important benchmark for both the allocation of reform and the analysis that follows. Contemporary criticism focused heavily on constituencies insulated from meaningful challenge through patronage and so-called “influence.” If geographic reform deliberately targeted such political closure, constituencies with histories of uncontested elections should experience greater disruption even conditional on their demographic circumstances. If they do not, the new geography appears not to have been systematically targeted toward places simply because their existing politics were uncompetitive. This also matters downstream because of how pre-reform competition predicts exposure to geographic change bears directly on how we interpret any discovered changes in competition.

Taken together, these expectations distinguish several substantively different accounts of geographic reallocation, which need not be mutually exclusive. The important comparison is whether otherwise similarly situated places received systematically different treatment according to their pre-reform socio-demographic or political characteristics. A map strongly structured by demographic conditions but largely unrelated to these political characteristics would indicate a surprisingly rule-bound process given the political stakes involved; systematic political differences conditional on those demographic pressures would instead reveal the way in which political interests shaped geographic allocation.

That distinction is also necessary for interpreting any *consequences* of reform. If pre-existing political interests systematically predict which places receive different geographic treatments, subsequent political outcomes may partly reflect the same forces that selected places into reform. If allocation instead follows comparatively rule-bound demographic criteria, the assignment process begins to offer greater leverage for separating geographic

reform from the political interests it subsequently affects. Understanding how the map was produced is therefore not just an important outcome to explain; it determines what can credibly be learned—especially causally—from the political changes that followed.

3.2 Representative Geography, Political Competition and Elite Persistence

Once a new representative geography is enacted, incumbents and potential challengers make choices within the political environments that map creates. Candidates value political office but face material, organizational, and reputational costs from seeking it, particularly when doing so entails publicly contesting—and potentially losing—an election. A potential challenger should therefore enter when the expected value of obtaining office, weighted by the perceived probability of success, exceeds those costs (Downs 1957; Palfrey 1984; Cox 1997). Electoral competition consequently depends not only upon voter preferences, but also upon what prospective candidates believe about the viability of challenging for a particular seat.

Stable representative environments allow those beliefs to become well established. Incumbents acquire reputations and relationships within particular geographic communities; patrons develop networks of influence; and repeated political interactions generate expectations about who possesses a plausible claim to represent a place. In nineteenth-century Britain these expectations rested on more than anticipated vote shares. Candidate viability could depend upon deference, patronage, property, familial claims, or longstanding connections between particular elites and constituencies (Gash 1953; Moore 1976; O’Gorman 1989; Hanham 1959). An uncontested election may therefore reflect not an absence of actors who value office, but an equilibrium in which potential challengers expect an established claimant to be sufficiently difficult to displace.

Changing representative geography can disrupt this equilibrium through two related mechanisms. First, redrawing a constituency changes the population whose support matters and makes previous political experience less informative about future outcomes. Potential candidates may know less about newly incorporated voters, incumbent strength among them, or the willingness of other candidates to enter. Second, reform can reduce the value of political resources upon which incumbent advantage depended. Name recognition, personalistic support, constituency service, patronage, and deference are often geographically embedded and need not transfer perfectly when the representative unit changes (Desposato and Petrocick 2003; Davis 1976; Ellis 1979). A landowner or patron exercising substantial influence over one electoral community may possess considerably less influence over populations incorporated from elsewhere. Geographic reform can therefore simultaneously increase uncertainty about who can win and weaken the political assets

that previously made the answer seem obvious. Both should encourage challenger entry.

The two channels imply somewhat different temporal patterns. Uncertainty should be especially important immediately after reform. Elections themselves reveal information, and expectations should regularize as actors acquire experience with the new map. Competition generated primarily by uncertainty should therefore be unusually pronounced around the transition rather than constituting a permanently higher rate of political turnover. By contrast, a durable reduction in the value of geographically specific resources can continue to disadvantage incumbents whose former political bases have been significantly altered.

The first empirical implication is therefore not merely that geographic reform should be associated with competition, but that the competitive disruption produced by reform should be reflected in incumbent persistence as well. Where the first post-reform electoral environment becomes more competitive, incumbent survival should decrease.

Institutional form matters because geographic reforms disturb these equilibria to different degrees. Newly created constituencies establish representative arenas in which no incumbent necessarily possesses an inherited claim; division can separate populations and political networks that previously operated together; and abolition eliminates an incumbent's existing representative base altogether. By contrast, enlargement can leave much of an existing political community intact, especially where newly incorporated populations remain within broader networks of landed or patronal influence. The historical organization of politics after 1832 similarly shows that new electoral institutions did not operate independently of existing social power: local party organization frequently developed around leading landed, commercial, manufacturing, religious, and professional elites (Spychal 2024). Formally substantial geographic reform can therefore either destabilize or accommodate existing influence depending upon how the new representative unit intersects with resources already present.

This possibility connects the consequences of reform directly to the politics of allocation developed above. Politically powerful actors may have been better able to obtain forms of reform that preserved the usefulness of their existing resources, even when they could not prevent reform itself. Geographic change should therefore not be interpreted as an as-if-random shock to incumbent politicians. The allocation and consequences of reform are distinct but they were related to politics. The same political factors that helped determine whether a constituency was abolished, enlarged, divided, or preserved may also affect subsequent competition and survival.

Yet even severe geographic disruption need not permanently displace existing elites. A large literature on democratization and political persistence emphasizes that institutional change can alter the channels through which elites exercise political influence without

eliminating the resources on which that influence rests (Przeworski 1991; Ziblatt 2017; Fresh 2025). Wealth, status, parliamentary experience, organizational capacity, family connections, and political networks may remain valuable even when a particular institutional advantage disappears (Hanham 1959; Perkin 1985). Elite persistence after reform can consequently reflect *adaptation* rather than simple insulation from change.

For geographic reform, the critical distinction is between resources that are geographically specific and those that are portable. Local patronage, residence, relationships with a particular electorate, and influence rooted in a particular constituency should depreciate when that political geography disappears. Other resources—political experience, social status, wealth, connections at the national level, or an established capacity to obtain representation in different places—can potentially be redeployed.

This distinction generates a sharper prediction than the general claim that “powerful” elites should survive. When an incumbent’s constituency is abolished, persistence should be greatest among politicians whose pre-reform careers already reveal that their political resources are not confined to a single geographic base. Prior service across multiple constituencies or counties therefore provides an observable indicator of demonstrated geographic portability, conceptually distinct from whether an MP was locally resident or otherwise rooted in the constituency represented immediately before reform.

Persistence itself can also take geographically different forms. An incumbent may retain the same constituency; move to another seat within the same regional political environment; or reconstruct a parliamentary career elsewhere. These outcomes distinguish institutional continuity from geographic adaptation. The distinction should be particularly informative following abolition. If incumbents whose constituencies disappear nevertheless return from entirely different parts of the country, continuity cannot simply be attributed to the preservation of their former local political base. Conversely, failure to persist after the destruction of that base would indicate that the resources supporting the previous political career were more geographically specific.

Competition and persistence are therefore complementary rather than competing measures of reform’s consequences. If geographic reform disrupts established political claims, it should encourage candidate entry and make incumbent survival less certain. But greater competition need not imply permanent elite displacement. Incumbents may initially face greater challenge, temporarily leave Parliament, or relocate geographically while ultimately reconstructing political careers. Reform can therefore change the *conditions under which* elites obtain and maintain office without immediately or permanently changing who possesses political power. This distinction is central to broader debates over whether democratization replaces incumbent elites or instead induces them to reorganize the bases

of their influence (Moore 1976; Ziblatt 2017).

The empirical implications follow directly. I examine whether different forms of geographic reform generated different levels of electoral competition; whether competition in the newly constituted electoral environment is associated with lower incumbent persistence; whether the reform transition produced an exceptional rather than permanent break in parliament-to-parliament elite persistence; and whether surviving incumbents retained their former geographic bases or adapted by seeking representation elsewhere. Finally, I focus on the most severe form of geographic disruption—the abolition of an incumbent’s constituency—and ask whether demonstrated pre-reform geographic mobility predicts the ability to reconstruct a parliamentary career. Together, these outcomes distinguish disruption of established political environments from the capacity of existing elites to adapt to them.

4 Data and Measurement

The empirical analysis requires observing three distinct objects—*i*) the places across which representation was redistributed, *ii*) the political and demographic characteristics that may have shaped that redistribution, and *iii*) the political actors and electoral environments that emerged from it. I therefore combine newly reconstructed parliamentary constituency boundaries with parish-level demographic and economic data, information on pre-reform political interests and reform pressure, and electoral and candidate-level data spanning the reform period.

Important to note from the outset is that different parts of the analysis use different units—stable geographic localities (parishes), constituencies (whose boundaries can change), and MPs—according to the political question being studied. Importantly, the parish provides a stable geographic unit through which places can be followed across a reform that changed the constituency boundaries themselves, thus ensuring for key analyses that estimated relationships are a function of the phenomenon under study and not the changing composition of the sample.

4.1 Constituency Boundaries and Representation

The principal institutional object of interest is the parliamentary constituency. To reconstruct the geography of representation, I collect constituency boundary maps from the National Archives series associated with the Drummond Boundary Commission (T 72) and related archival sources. As described above, these maps were themselves products of an unusually extensive state survey. They record parish and administrative boundaries, houses, buildings, roads, and other features at a highly detailed scale (Figure 3). I

digitize and georeference these maps to construct a geospatial dataset of parliamentary constituencies immediately before and after the Great Reform Act.

The reconstruction of pre-1832 boundaries is particularly important because, to my knowledge, no comprehensive geospatial data of English parliamentary constituencies exists for the period immediately preceding reform. The resulting data therefore make it possible to observe systematically both the representative geography inherited by reformers *and* the geography that emerged from reform.²⁰ Unless otherwise noted, the pre-reform boundaries correspond to constituencies in place between 1828 and 1832, while the post-reform boundaries correspond to those established in 1832.²¹

I use these maps to code the institutional changes described in the historical section. Constituencies may gain or lose parliamentary seats, be newly enfranchised or disfranchised, or experience geographic change while retaining representation. Among surviving boroughs, I distinguish extensions to the “modern town” from the multiple-parish extensions used to create sufficiently large electorates under the new franchise. Counties could instead be divided into separate representative units.

One complication is that “no boundary change” does not necessarily imply an unchanged *representative* environment. A county boundary, for example, could remain formally intact while a newly enfranchised borough was carved from the population it previously represented. This is one reason the analyses below also follow individual localities (parishes) across the changing map rather than treating constituency labels themselves as stable units.

It is similarly important to distinguish the geography of *representation* from the geography of the *franchise*. The reconstructed boundaries identify the populations assigned to common parliamentary representation, not who was legally entitled to vote within them. Older borough franchises could be highly restrictive and, in some cases, attached voting rights to particular properties rather than the broader resident population.²² Con-

²⁰I validate the post-reform boundaries against existing GIS files obtained through the UK Data Archive. In most cases the boundaries coincide; where they do not, I return to the archival record to distinguish boundaries initially proposed by the Commission from those ultimately enacted by Parliament.

²¹Several constituencies experienced substantial geographic reforms before the Great Reform Act. New Shoreham (1771), Cricklade (1782), Aylesbury (1802), and East Retford (1828) were enlarged following controversies over corruption and electoral influence, while Grampound was disfranchised. These so-called Clause 5 boroughs, along with Grampound, are discussed in Appendix F.

²²In some cases in the pre-reformed parliament, a voter’s connection to a place was incredibly loose. Many constituencies allowed non-resident freemen to vote, and there were no clear rules or procedures for preventing someone from qualifying to vote in multiple locations (Porritt 1903; Seymour 1970; Phillips 1982). Many of these irregularities and idiosyncracies were precisely what the reform was designed to address. Connecting the reconstructed boundaries to the particular franchise arrangements operating within each borough would permit a complementary reconstruction of the geography of enfranchisement. The present analysis instead focuses on the geographic allocation of parliamentary representation to people.

stituency boundaries nevertheless defined the territorial units to which parliamentary representation was formally assigned. I therefore combine the reconstructed geography with historical information on the number of MPs returned by each constituency.

Places, Population, and Economic Geography

Because the constituency is itself changed by reform, I use parishes as the stable geographic units through which places are followed across the pre- and post-reform maps. Population data come from the parish-level census reconstructions assembled by the Cambridge Group for the History of Population and Social Structure (CGHPSS) and historical demographers working with the Integrated Census of England and Wales (Shaw-Taylor et al. 2015).²³ These data provide decennial population counts beginning in 1801, allowing me to measure both population on the eve of reform and population growth over the preceding decades. Where population is required for the start year of a parliament, I linearly interpolate between census observations.²⁴

The underlying population data are measured using the constant parish units constructed by Shaw-Taylor et al. (2015), which reconcile historical changes in parish definitions over time. For estimation, I further combine parishes that possess identical histories of parliamentary representation into 483 aggregated parish units. This is a computational convenience only—the constituent parishes remain the underlying observations represented by each unit, and parish-level analyses are weighted by the number of constituent parishes.²⁵ The resulting geography is extremely fine grained. The average parish covers approximately 12 square kilometers, and ninety percent cover less than 24 square kilometers. I then link these stable geographic units to parliamentary representation using geospatial overlays.²⁶

Population is an important, but not the only geographic claim emphasized by reformers. The theory also distinguishes population *growth* and economic development, which cap-

²³See also Wrigley and Schofield (1989) and Shaw-Taylor et al. (2015) for the construction of the historical population series.

²⁴The substantive results are robust to assuming constant growth rates between census observations rather than linear interpolation.

²⁵There are just over 11,600 constant parish units in England. Aggregating only units with identical representative histories leaves all variables relevant to the geographic treatment constant within the resulting unit. Appendix specifications additionally weight observations by parish population in 1801 to answer distinct questions.

²⁶Most parishes nest cleanly within constituencies. Where a constituency boundary intersects a parish, I assign parish population proportionately according to the share of parish area falling within each constituency. This procedure assumes that population is distributed uniformly within the intersected parish. Given the small geographic scale of most parishes and the absence of systematic sub-parish population data, it provides a transparent way to assign population to reconstructed historical constituencies. Small gaps arising from digitization tolerances are likewise redistributed proportionately across intersecting units.

ture the changing demographic and economic geography produced by industrialization rather than simply the size of a place in 1831. Population growth is measured from the same census series described above.

Economic structure is measured using the share of employed men age twenty and older working in secondary-sector occupations, constructed from geographically disaggregated occupational data assembled by the Cambridge Group for the History of Population and Social Structure and the Great Britain Historical Database (Kitson et al. 2010; Southall 2005). Occupations are classified using the Primary–Secondary–Tertiary (PST) system, with the secondary sector capturing manufacturing and, following Wrigley (2010), mining. Because the consistently defined occupational data surrounding reform are observed in 1817 and 1851, I linearly interpolate between those observations to construct the 1831 measure.²⁷

Political Interests and Reform Pressure

The allocation analysis also uses measures of the political environment that existed *before* the geographic settlement was enacted. Three come from the data assembled by Aidt and Franck (2019): constituency-level petitioning on parliamentary reform, patronal control, and the factional alignment of sitting MPs. Together, these capture distinct dimensions of the pre-reform political environment—popular pressure for reform, the strength of established political control, and alignment with the coalition sponsoring reform. I supplement these measures with a measure of prior electoral competition constructed from my constituency-level election data.

Reform pressure is measured using Aidt and Franck’s net petition measure. Using the *Journals of the House of Commons* for 1828–1831, they identify petitions concerning parliamentary reform originating in each English constituency and calculate the number supporting reform minus the number opposing it. Patronal control is also taken from their data. They use constituency histories in Philbin (1965) and electoral records in Cannon (1972) to identify constituencies subject to full or partial control by a local patron or the Treasury, as well as constituencies that had experienced no contested election since 1802. Factional alignment is measured from their classification of pre-reform MPs as Whig/Radical or Tory, assembled from contemporary and biographical sources including Dod and Dod (1908), Smith (1973), and Fisher (2009). I aggregate these affiliations to the constituency level as the share of MPs aligned with the Whig/Radical reform coalition.

Finally, I measure the prior openness of constituency politics using the share of pre-1832

²⁷Early occupational records sometimes identify workers simply as “laborers,” without assigning them to an economic sector. I follow the approach developed by Keibek (2017) to allocate otherwise unclassified laborers between agricultural and non-agricultural employment.

elections that were contested. This measure is constructed from my constituency-level electoral data and captures a constituency’s recent history of contestation rather than whether the election immediately preceding reform happened to be contested. A higher value therefore indicates a political environment in which electoral challenge had been more common before the Reform Act.

4.2 Measuring Representational Change

The institutional categories above describe the particular forms reform took. To compare their implications for places using a common quantity, I also measure each parish’s representative position before and after reform using population represented per MP. Let $c(i, t)$ denote the parliamentary constituency containing parish i in parliament t . I define

$$PopulationPerMP_{it} = \frac{\sum_{p \in c(i,t)} Population_{pt}}{Seats_{c(i,t),t}}. \quad (1)$$

The numerator is therefore the total population represented by the constituency containing parish i , while the denominator is the number of MPs returned by that constituency. Holding population fixed, a parish receives greater representation when it is placed in a smaller representative unit or when its constituency receives additional MPs; it receives less when it is incorporated into a larger representative unit or loses seats. This consequently captures both the redistribution of parliamentary seats *and* the redistribution of populations across constituency boundaries in one measure.

Throughout the paper, I use “improvement” in representation as shorthand for a reduction in population represented per MP—that is, an increase in a place’s parliamentary representation relative to its population. A deterioration denotes the reverse. This terminology does not presume that population equality was the only or primary criterion associated with reform. Population per MP instead provides a common quantity with which to compare otherwise heterogeneous geographic and institutional changes.

For the main specifications, I classify parishes into three categories according to this measure—those experiencing an improvement in representation, those experiencing a deterioration, and those experiencing no meaningful change.²⁸ Re-weighting the aggregated geographic units to the underlying parishes, approximately 85% of parishes experienced an improvement in representation, 10% experienced a deterioration, and 5% experienced

²⁸The classification is based on the proportional change in population represented per MP between the pre- and post-reform representative environments. A parish is classified as experiencing no meaningful change when the absolute percentage change is less than 5%. This tolerance distinguishes substantive changes in representation from small differences generated by population growth, interpolation, digitization tolerances, and the reconstruction of historical geography. Requiring population per MP to remain exactly constant would produce an unrealistically small comparison group.

no meaningful change.

I also measure the magnitude of representational change continuously as

$$\Delta PopulationPerMP_i = \ln \left(\frac{PopulationPerMP_{i,1833}}{PopulationPerMP_{i,1831}} \right). \quad (2)$$

Negative values indicate that fewer people are represented per MP after reform, while positive values indicate the reverse. This measure preserves both the direction in addition to the magnitude of representational change. It then allows the analysis to distinguish whether the correlates and consequences of reform vary along the intensive as well as the extensive margin.

The use of population rather than the electorate is deliberate. The concept is the population *represented* by an MP, not simply the number legally entitled to select that MP. Reform debates repeatedly concerned the relationship between representatives and the broader communities whose interests and claims they purported to articulate, including people who did not possess the franchise.²⁹

4.3 Electoral Competition and Elite Persistence

I measure electoral competition in two ways. A constituency is coded as contested when the number of candidates exceeds the number of seats available, and the number of challengers is defined as the number of candidates in excess of those seats. These measures capture both whether an electoral challenge occurred and the number of additional candidates entering the contest. I focus on the first parliamentary return following reform; by-elections, which could arise from death, succession to the House of Lords, disputed returns, and other mid-parliament events, are examined separately.

Pre-1832 electoral data come from constituency histories produced by the History of Parliament Project (HPP).³⁰ I compile candidate lists and election outcomes from newly scraped and structured constituency histories (see also Fresh (2024)). For the post-1832 period, I use the constituency-level election data assembled by Eggers and Spirling (2014). Together, these sources provide comparable measures of candidate entry and contestation across the reform period.

I also examine the persistence of MPs who held English seats immediately before reform.

²⁹Political influence in nineteenth-century Britain likewise operated through channels extending beyond voting itself. Petitions, collective action, and other forms of engagement frequently involved individuals who could not vote but nevertheless sought to influence parliamentary behavior (Aidt and Leon-Ablan 2023).

³⁰(HPP 2013).

The central distinction is between preservation of an incumbent’s existing geographic position and adaptation that allows the same politician to remain in Parliament through a different constituency. I therefore distinguish MPs who return through the same named constituency, those who return elsewhere, and those who do not return to the English Commons.

Because person identifiers are not consistent across the pre- and post-reform sources, I construct a reviewed cross-source linkage using names together with parliamentary and biographical information, manually checking ambiguous cases. The principal outcomes indicate whether an MP returned to any English constituency in 1833 and whether he appeared at least once through 1841. Non-return is coded as exit from the English Commons regardless of whether it resulted from electoral defeat, retirement, death, succession to the Lords, or another cause, so the measure captures parliamentary persistence rather than electoral defeat specifically. MP-level analyses additionally account for pre-reform parliamentary experience and characteristics capturing the resources available for political adaptation, including social status, family parliamentary connections, landed and capital interests, prior geographic mobility, and whether an MP’s residence was tied to his 1831 constituency. Specifications relating post-reform electoral competition to persistence also condition on prior constituency competition and the form of geographic reform.

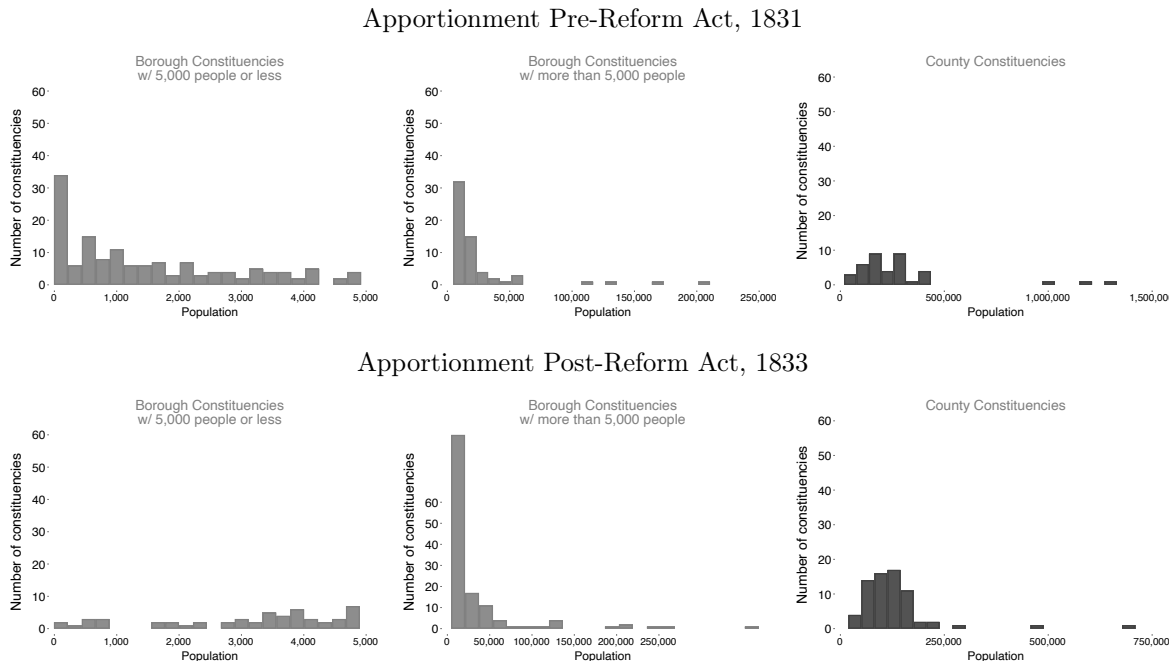
5 The Reallocation of Geographic Representation

The theoretical argument implies that geographic reform should reflect neither a mechanical response to population nor unconstrained political manipulation. Demographic claims should structure which representative arrangements were increasingly difficult to defend, while political interests should matter particularly where those claims left room for alternative institutional responses. I therefore examine the construction of the post-reform map in two stages. First, I ask whether representational weight was systematically redistributed toward more populous places. I then turn from the *direction* of redistribution to its *institutional form*, asking whether political characteristics help distinguish among the ways in which reformers reorganized existing representative units.

The analysis is descriptive rather than causal.³¹ The objective is instead to characterize systematically the process through which the map was constructed: where representational weight moved, and which demographic and political characteristics distin-

³¹Population, economic structure, and political characteristics were not randomly distributed across England and may be related to other characteristics that also affected reform. Population nevertheless has an unusually direct interpretation in this setting: demographic imbalance was an avowed object of reform, and the 1831 census supplied information available to the Boundary Commission as it investigated the geography of representation.

Figure 5: Geographic apportionment of parliamentary representation before and after the 1832 Reform Act



Notes: The plots show the distribution of population across parliamentary constituencies before and after the Great Reform Act. The unit of analysis is the constituency rather than the seat. The two left-hand plots separate borough constituencies with 5,000 people or less from those with more than 5,000 people; the right-hand plots show county constituencies. Population is calculated from the decennial parish population data described in Section 4.

guished among the institutional arrangements through which that redistribution was accomplished.

Figure 5 provides a first view of the problem reform confronted and the settlement that followed. On the eve of reform, parliamentary representation was distributed across constituencies with extraordinarily different populations: very small boroughs coexisted with much larger urban constituencies, while large county constituencies encompassed still greater populations. The post-reform distributions show substantial reorganization but not the replacement of the inherited system with a uniform population-based apportionment rule. The remainder of this section examines that combination of demographic reallocation and institutional continuity more systematically.

5.1 The Direction and Magnitude of Representational Reallocation

The appropriate unit of analysis depends upon the question being asked. To study *where representational weight moved*, the constituency is problematic because constituencies were themselves abolished, created, divided, and redrawn by the Reform Act. I therefore use the stable parish geographies described in Section 4 to follow places through the chang-

ing representative map. This allows me to ask whether people living in more populous places systematically emerged from reform in more favorable representative environments regardless of the institutional mechanism through which the change occurred.

I measure representational change in two ways. First, a parish is classified as experiencing an improvement if population represented per MP declined by more than five percent between the pre- and post-reform environments. Second, I examine the magnitude of change, measured as the log ratio of population represented per MP after and before reform, separately among places experiencing improvements and deteriorations. Negative values therefore indicate improved representation and positive values deteriorated representation.

I estimate specifications of the form

$$Y_i = \alpha + \beta \ln(\text{Population}_{i,1831}) + \gamma_r + \varepsilon_i, \quad (3)$$

where i indexes the stable parish unit and γ_r denotes region fixed effects. Because the underlying data aggregate parishes sharing the same representational history, observations are weighted by the number of constituent parishes so that the estimates describe parish experiences rather than reconstructed geographic units.³²

Table 3 shows that population strongly structured the broad redistribution of representation. A one-unit increase in logged population—approximately a 2.7-fold difference in population—is associated with a nine percentage-point increase in the probability that a parish experienced improved representation. Among places whose representation improved, larger populations experienced less extreme improvements; among places whose representation deteriorated, larger populations experienced less extreme deteriorations. The largest proportional disruptions in either direction were therefore concentrated among relatively small places.³³

The central result is consequently straightforward: representational weight moved systematically toward more populous places. But this does not mean that population mechanically determined the new map. Similar changes in population represented per MP could be produced through additional seats, county division, new borough creation, or changes in constituency boundaries. The parish analysis identifies the broad direction

³²Results are robust to using population measured in 1802 or 1820. The choice of census year was itself discussed during the reform process.

³³Appendix H shows the underlying relationship nonparametrically. Separate Lowess fits for places experiencing improvements and deteriorations in representation produce the same pattern: the magnitude of representational change is greatest among relatively small places.

Table 3: Population and the reallocation of parliamentary representation in 1832

	Pr(Pop per MP decreased)	Δ Pop per MP	
		decrease == 1	increase == 1
	(1)	(2)	(3)
$\ln(\text{Population}_{1831})$	0.091*** (0.017)	0.39*** (0.036)	-0.45*** (0.078)
Region FE	✓	✓	✓
Parish weighted	✓	✓	✓
Sample w/ decreased pop/MP ratio only		✓	
Sample w/ increased pop/MP ratio only			✓
Nations	England	England	England
Years	1833	1833	1833
Obsv	483	283	150
Mean of DV (weighted)	0.85	-0.99	0.66
SD of DV (weighted)	0.35	0.67	1.30

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: OLS regressions with robust standard errors. The unit of analysis is the aggregated parish unit described in Section 4, re-weighted to the parish using the number of constituent parishes in each unit. Column (1) examines whether a parish experienced an improvement in representation, defined as a reduction of more than 5% in population represented per MP. Columns (2) and (3) examine the magnitude of representational change conditional on experiencing an improvement or deterioration. The dependent variable is the log ratio of population represented per MP after and before reform. Region fixed effects are included in all models. Observations associated with very small reconstructed constituency populations are excluded.

of redistribution; it deliberately abstracts from the institutional choices through which reformers produced it.

5.2 The Form of Geographic Reform

To study those choices, the pre-reform constituency becomes the appropriate unit of analysis. This is not simply a change in observational convenience. Existing boroughs and counties were themselves the institutional objects upon which reformers acted: Parliament decided whether particular boroughs would survive, lose seats, or be enlarged, and whether particular counties would remain intact or be divided. The pre-reform constituency therefore corresponds to the meaningful choice unit for asking why reform took one institutional form rather than another.

Existing boroughs could be completely disfranchised, reduced in representation, preserved, enlarged into surrounding parishes, or extended to encompass the “modern town”; counties could be divided. These alternatives could respond to similar representational problems while carrying different consequences for existing political interests. I therefore ask whether the demographic, economic, and political characteristics of pre-reform constituencies distinguish among the institutional treatments they received.

The predictors follow directly from the theory. Population and population growth capture the demographic claims confronting reformers. Economic structure is measured using the

share of the male workforce employed in secondary-sector occupations, constructed from the census occupational data described in Section 4. Net petitions in favor of parliamentary reform measure locally articulated demand for reform. Finally, patronal control, the Whig/Radical share of a constituency’s parliamentary delegation in 1830, and prior electoral competition capture different dimensions of the political organization embedded in the inherited representative system.

I estimate specifications of the general form

$$Pr(Y_i^k = 1) = \alpha_k + \beta_k \ln(Population_{i,1831}) + \delta_k PopulationGrowth_i + \quad (4)$$

$$\theta_k EconomicStructure_i + \lambda_k PoliticalCharacteristics_i + \gamma_r + \varepsilon_i, \quad (5)$$

where i indexes the pre-reform constituency and k indexes a particular institutional treatment. The outcomes are estimated separately because the different forms of reform do not lie along a single ordered dimension. The coefficients are interpreted descriptively. They identify characteristics that distinguish constituencies receiving different institutional treatments rather than causal effects of those characteristics on parliamentary decisions.

Table 4 reveals a useful distinction between the broad constraints on reform and the politics of its institutional form. Population remains important where demographic scale most directly implicated the inherited allocation of representation. Larger boroughs were substantially less likely to be completely disfranchised and less likely to lose a seat, while larger counties were substantially more likely to be divided. Population growth and secondary-sector employment, by contrast, do not systematically predict these outcomes. Thus, although industrialization and demographic change produced the broader mismatch between Britain’s economic geography and its inherited representative institutions, the particular allocation of reform across existing constituencies is much more clearly related to population scale than to occupational composition.

The political results differ in an important respect. Patronal control did not protect boroughs from complete disfranchisement. Among boroughs that survived, patronally controlled constituencies were instead approximately sixteen percentage points more likely to lose a seat. Existing political power therefore did not simply insulate inherited representative units from change.

Its clearest relationship appears in the *form* that geographic adaptation took. Patronally controlled boroughs were approximately twenty-four percentage points less likely to be enlarged toward the “modern town,” but thirty percentage points more likely to be en-

Table 4: The demographic and political correlates of geographic reform

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
ln(Population), 1831	-0.065*** (0.023)	-0.061** (0.023)	-0.0099 (0.030)	-0.042 (0.028)	0.36*** (0.10)
Population growth, 1802–1831	-0.12 (0.12)	0.11 (0.17)	-0.065 (0.15)	-0.10 (0.16)	-0.16 (0.96)
% Employed in secondary sector	0.18 (0.27)	-0.18 (0.27)	0.054 (0.39)	-0.59* (0.34)	0.074 (0.66)
Net reform petitions	-0.031 (0.021)	-0.011 (0.015)	0.0032 (0.025)	-0.017 (0.017)	
Patronal/closed control	0.066 (0.055)	0.16** (0.068)	-0.24** (0.10)	0.30*** (0.071)	
Whig/Radical seat share, 1830	-0.00087 (0.00090)	0.0017* (0.00098)	-0.00054 (0.0012)	0.0022** (0.0011)	
Share pre-reform elections contested	-0.24** (0.11)	-0.078 (0.12)	0.37** (0.15)	-0.15 (0.13)	
Region FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Borough Sample		✓	✓	✓	
County Sample					✓
Sample	All	Surviving	Surviving	Surviving	Counties
Obsv	180	129	129	129	39
Mean of DV	0.27	0.19	0.43	0.30	0.69

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: OLS regressions with robust standard errors. The unit of analysis is the pre-reform constituency. Column (1) examines complete disfranchisement among existing boroughs. Columns (2)–(4) examine alternative forms of reform among surviving boroughs. Column (5) examines division among pre-reform counties. Economic structure is measured using the share of the male workforce employed in secondary-sector occupations. Region fixed effects are included in all models.

larged into surrounding parishes. Historically more competitive boroughs display the opposite pattern for modern-town extension: constituencies with a greater history of electoral contestation were substantially more likely to receive boundaries corresponding to the modern town. These results fit the theoretical distinction between preventing reform and adapting to it. Political interests did not necessarily preserve the inherited geography unchanged; they were associated with the particular geographic solution through which an existing representative unit survived the transition.

Partisan alignment also bears on the settlement, but not in the simple form familiar from modern partisan redistricting. Greater Whig/Radical representation does not predict protection from disfranchisement. Among surviving boroughs, however, Whig/Radical seat share is positively associated with seat reduction and with enlargement into surrounding parishes; in the latter case, moving from an entirely non-Whig/Radical to an entirely Whig/Radical delegation is associated with roughly a twenty-two percentage-point increase in the probability of parish extension. The evidence therefore suggests that partisan alignment was related to particular institutional choices, but not that Whigs simply used reform to protect constituencies represented by their own side. This is consistent with a political system in which party was only one among several bases of political organization,

alongside patrons, families, landed interests, and personal political connections.

Net reform petitions, meanwhile, do not systematically distinguish among the institutional outcomes. This does not imply that demands for reform were unimportant in producing the national reform settlement. It suggests instead that constituency-level variation in formal petitions did little to predict which particular geographic remedy a place subsequently received.

Taken together, the results produce a coherent account of the construction of the new map. Population strongly structured the redistribution of representational weight and the broad limits of which inherited arrangements could be sustained. Political organization mattered most clearly in the institutional form through which surviving constituencies were adapted to reform. The settlement therefore looks neither like mechanical apportionment nor like unconstrained partisan mapmaking. Demographic principles imposed real structure, while historically specific forms of political power operated within the room those principles left for institutional choice.³⁴

This account also matters for interpreting the political consequences of reform. The constituencies that emerged in 1832 were not randomly assigned geographic treatments. Some changes followed from strong demographic pressures, while others reflected choices among politically consequential institutional alternatives. The next section therefore asks whether different changes to representative geography were associated with subsequent electoral competition and elite persistence, treating the endogeneity of the map as part of the political process rather than assuming it away.

6 Geographic Representation, Electoral Competition and Elite Persistence

The preceding section showed that the representative map enacted in 1832 was itself a political outcome. Population strongly structured the redistribution of representational weight, while political characteristics were associated with the particular institutional forms through which existing constituencies were reorganized.

I now turn to the consequences of that settlement. The analysis proceeds from electoral

³⁴One important component of the settlement remains outside the preceding constituency-based analysis: the creation of new boroughs in places that lacked independent parliamentary representation before reform. Because such places were not pre-reform constituencies, they cannot enter the same risk set without defining a different universe of possible recipients. A descriptive comparison using the stable geographic units employed above indicates that places incorporated into new boroughs were substantially more populous on the eve of reform than other areas outside the existing borough system. Because those units were constructed to follow representational histories rather than to identify the set of plausible candidate towns, I do not treat that comparison as an analysis of new-borough selection.

Figure 6: Electoral contestation before and after the Great Reform Act



Notes: The figure reports the share of parliamentary constituencies experiencing a contested election in the first electoral return for each parliament. A return is contested when more candidates seek election than there are seats available. The vertical line marks the Great Reform Act. Because constituencies were abolished, created, divided, and redrawn in 1832, the set of constituencies changes at reform.

environments to the politicians who operated within them. I first examine whether the different constituencies produced by reform exhibited different levels of competition, and secondarily, how stable places experienced competition as the boundaries around them changed. I finally ask whether this competitive disruption translated into turnover among incumbent MPs and, where it did, which political resources allowed incumbents to adapt to the new geography.

Many of the analyses attend to causal questions but constructing a good counterfactual is challenging. Constituencies were not randomly assigned to reform categories, nor were the places whose representative environments changed otherwise interchangeable with those whose environments remained stable.

6.1 Electoral Competition in the Reformed Geography

The first parliamentary return under the reformed system coincided with a pronounced increase in the share of constituencies experiencing contested elections (Figure 6). Contestation remained considerably more common thereafter as compared to much of the pre-reform period.³⁵

To understand this pattern, I empirically evaluate which constituencies experienced this

³⁵Because the constituency map itself changes at reform, this series should not be read as a same-unit estimate of the effect of the Act. It instead establishes the aggregate phenomenon to be explained.

increasing in reform. I ask whether different specific *forms* of representative geography were associated with different political environments in the first post-reform election. To do so, for constituency i , I use OLS to estimate

$$y_i = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{RepReduced}_i + \beta_2 \text{RepIncreased}_i + \beta_3 \text{NewBorough}_i + \beta_4 \text{CountySplit}_i + \beta_5 \text{ParishExtension}_i + \beta_6 \text{TownExtension}_i + X_i \Gamma + \varepsilon_i, \quad (6)$$

where y_i is either an indicator for a contested return or the number of challengers. The predictor variables are indicators for each type of general representational or boundary change, with the omitted category being constituencies experiencing no listed change to representation or their principal boundaries.³⁶ In the controlled specifications, X_i includes logged constituency population, borough status, and region indicators.³⁷

An important feature of this specification is that I do not mechanically control for pre-reform competition. Newly created boroughs and divided counties have no corresponding pre-reform constituency from which such a measure can be produced. Assigning them the electoral history of the constituency that previously encompassed their territory would silently change the unit of analysis. The parish analysis below makes precisely that move explicitly—rather than pretending that new and old constituencies are the same units, it follows stable places through the change in representative institutions.

Table 5 shows surprisingly little systematic differentiation across most forms of reform. New boroughs, divided counties, constituencies gaining or losing representation, and boroughs enlarged toward the modern town do not consistently differ from comparatively unchanged constituencies once basic demographic and regional characteristics are taken into account. The important exception is enlargement to surrounding parishes. In the controlled specification, these boroughs are approximately eighteen percentage points less likely to experience a contested return, although the estimate is imprecise. The challenger outcome is considerably sharper, however—parish extensions attract approximately 0.45 fewer challengers than otherwise comparable unchanged constituencies.

This result connects directly to the allocation analysis in the previous section. Patronal controlled boroughs were substantially more likely to receive parish extensions and substantially less likely to be extended toward their modern towns. The type of geographic reform most strongly associated with existing patronal organization is also the form asso-

³⁶Note that constituencies can experience representation changes *and* boundary changes.

³⁷I do not condition on the size of the post-reform electorate. The electorate was itself jointly produced by the franchise provisions of the Reform Act and the geographic boundaries through which those provisions operated. Appendix G shows this relationship directly. I show that among surviving pre-reform boroughs, the form of boundary enlargement is strongly associated with the size of the post-reform electorate, even conditional on constituency population.

Table 5: Geographic reform and electoral competition in the first post-reform election

	Pr(Contest)		Number of Challengers	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Representation reduced	-0.14 (0.13)	-0.13 (0.13)	-0.096 (0.17)	-0.067 (0.19)
Representation increased	-0.24 (0.20)	-0.16 (0.24)	-0.56** (0.22)	-0.45 (0.30)
New borough constituency	0.069 (0.079)	0.043 (0.085)	0.33* (0.18)	0.24 (0.18)
Split county	-0.12 (0.087)	0.000076 (0.18)	-0.31** (0.14)	-0.094 (0.27)
Enlarged to parish	-0.20* (0.11)	-0.18 (0.12)	-0.50*** (0.17)	-0.45** (0.18)
Enlarged to modern town	0.024 (0.078)	0.047 (0.083)	-0.0047 (0.15)	0.042 (0.16)
ln(Population)		0.048** (0.024)		0.13** (0.051)
Borough		0.23 (0.17)		0.50* (0.27)
Region: Midlands		0.0040 (0.086)		-0.100 (0.13)
Region: East		0.074 (0.10)		0.21 (0.19)
Region: Southeast		0.10 (0.077)		0.18 (0.14)
Region: Southwest		-0.030 (0.089)		-0.047 (0.14)
Region FE		✓		✓
Nations	England	England	England	England
Years	1833 only	1833 only	1833 only	1833 only
Obsv	254	254	254	254
Mean of DV	0.73	0.73	0.98	0.98
SD of DV	0.44	0.44	0.76	0.76

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: OLS regressions with robust standard errors in parentheses. The unit of analysis is the constituency in the first post-reform parliament. Contestation equals one when more candidates seek election than seats are available; the number of challengers is the number of candidates in excess of available seats. By-elections are excluded. The omitted category consists of constituencies with no listed change to either parliamentary representation or their principal boundaries. The controlled specifications include logged constituency population, borough status, and region indicators. The estimates characterize differences among the selected institutional forms produced by reform and are not interpreted as causal effects of reform category.

ciated with the least challenger entry after reform. That alignment is consistent with the argument that existing political power could operate through *adaptation* to reform rather than outright prevention of it. Though we cannot say, however that patronal influence causally produced the subsequent competitive outcome given how this type of geography was politically created.³⁸

³⁸A useful narrower comparison supports the same interpretation. Among surviving pre-reform boroughs, where prior electoral competition can be defined without changing the unit of analysis, enlargement to surrounding parishes is associated with an approximately 23 percentage-point lower probability of a contested return after conditioning on the borough's pre-reform history of contestation. Modern-town

6.2 Following Places Through Geographic Reorganization

The constituency comparison describes the electoral institutions that emerged from reform, but it cannot tell us directly what happened to particular geographic localities as the map changed. For that purpose, I return to the stable parish units used in the allocation analysis. This is substantively important rather than merely a robustness exercise. Constituencies are outcomes of reform; parishes provide a way to hold place constant while its representative environment changes.

For each stable geographic unit p , I classify the change in population represented per MP between 1831 and 1833. A place experiences an improvement if population represented per MP falls by more than five percent, a deterioration if it rises by more than five percent, and no meaningful change otherwise.³⁹ I estimate specifications of the form

$$y_{pt} = \alpha_p + \lambda_t + \beta_1 (\text{Improved}_p \times \text{Post1832}_t) + \beta_2 (\text{Deteriorated}_p \times \text{Post1832}_t) + X_{pt}\Gamma + \varepsilon_{pt}, \quad (7)$$

where α_p are parish-unit fixed effects and λ_t are parliament fixed effects. The outcomes are again contestation and the number of challengers. Some specifications additionally include contemporaneous logged population.⁴⁰ Observations are weighted by the number of underlying parishes represented by each stable geographic unit, and standard errors are clustered across units sharing a representational history.⁴¹

Table 6 reveals a different and more general pattern. Relative to stable places experiencing minimal change in their representative environment, places experiencing *either direction* of meaningful representational change became more competitive after reform. A reduction in population represented per MP is associated with roughly a thirteen percentage-point increase in contestation; an increase in population represented per MP is associated with an increase of approximately seventeen to eighteen percentage points. Challenger entry moves in the same direction, although the estimates are less precise.

The symmetry is substantively meaningful. If competition responded simply to an improvement in the quantity of representation, one would expect the relationship to operate primarily among places receiving fewer people per MP. Instead, competition rises among

extension, the other borough enlargement type, exhibits no comparable relationship.

³⁹The results are robust to other comparable thresholds. The use of the threshold attempts to separate small revisions in boundaries from highly meaningful ones.

⁴⁰Again they do not include a measure of voters. In the case of the parish analyses, there are no reliable parish-level voter measures. One could construct measures of males with certain economic characteristics or taxpaying behavior from census data, but these would necessarily be rough approximations even in the case where the pre-reform franchise was a function of property or taxpaying, and extremely poor measures for other franchise qualifications.

⁴¹Population weighted analyses, which answer a related but different question are in Appendix E.

Table 6: Representational change and electoral competition within places

	Pr(Contest)		Number of Challengers	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Pop per MP decreased $\times$ post-1832	0.13** (0.067)	0.13* (0.068)	0.14 (0.099)	0.14 (0.100)
Pop per MP increased $\times$ post-1832	0.18** (0.071)	0.17** (0.071)	0.19* (0.099)	0.18* (0.099)
Parliament FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Parish FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Parish weighted	✓	✓	✓	✓
Nations	England	England	England	England
Years	1802-1864	1802-1864	1802-1864	1802-1864
Obsv	8208	8208	8203	8203
Mean of DV (weighted)	0.30	0.30	0.37	0.37
SD of DV (weighted)	0.46	0.46	0.60	0.60

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: OLS regressions with parliament and stable parish-unit fixed effects. Standard errors are robust to clustering units that share a unique representational history. The constructed geographic units are re-weighted by the number of constituent parishes. “Pop per MP decreased” identifies places whose population represented per MP fell by more than 5% between the pre- and post-reform representative environments; “Pop per MP increased” identifies places whose ratio rose by more than 5%. Places changing by no more than 5% form the omitted category. Columns (2) and (4) additionally control for contemporaneous logged population. The sample is England, 1802–1864. By-elections are excluded.

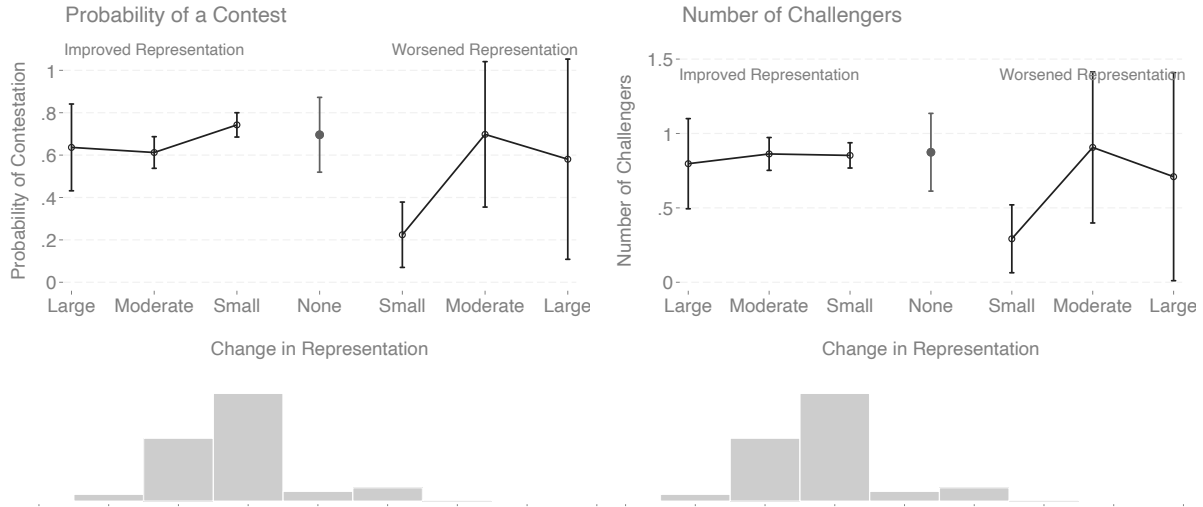
places whose representative environments changed substantially in *either direction*. This is consistent with the mechanism of disruption—rearranging which populations are represented together is expected to change established political relationships, candidate pools, and viable claims to representation regardless of whether the resulting population-to-seat ratio becomes mathematically more favorable or less favorable.⁴²

Figure 7 shows the same relationship without imposing a linear relationship between the magnitude of representational change and competition. The upper panels report competition across categories of representational change, while the lower panels show the distribution of parishes underlying those estimates. The latter are substantively useful because changes in representation were distributed very unevenly across places. More generally, the estimates do not suggest that progressively larger changes in population per MP mechanically generated progressively more competition. Rather, the clearest distinction is between places whose representative environments changed meaningfully and places whose environments remained comparatively stable.

Together, the two levels of analysis point to complementary features of the reformed map.

⁴²As a pre-reform diagnostic, I estimate analogous placebo interactions for the period immediately preceding 1832. Neither subsequent improvement nor deterioration in representation is associated with a statistically distinguishable differential change in electoral competition before reform, providing no evidence that the main pattern simply continues a pre-existing divergence across the subsequent reform categories.

Figure 7: Representational change and competition in the first post-reform election



Notes: The upper panels relate the direction and magnitude of representational change generated by the Great Reform Act to electoral competition in the first parliamentary return after reform. Representation is measured as population represented per MP. Within the categories experiencing improvements or deteriorations, places are grouped according to the magnitude of change. Points report parish-weighted means and vertical bars report 95% confidence intervals. The center category consists of places experiencing no meaningful change, defined as an absolute change of no more than 5% in population represented per MP. The lower panels show the corresponding distribution of parish observations across the same categories of representational change. They therefore indicate the amount of empirical support underlying the estimates in the upper panels and help account for differences in precision across categories.

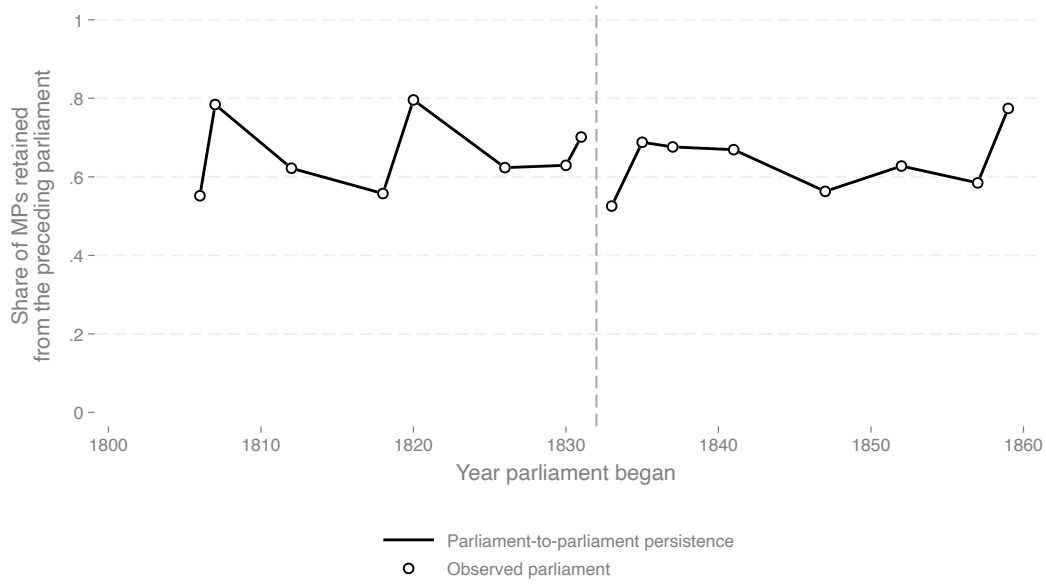
At the constituency level, institutional form mattered because parish extensions stand out as unusually resistant to challenger entry. This is consistent with the political organization associated with their creation. At the place level, however, the broader pattern is disruption. Stable geographic communities whose representative environments changed subsequently experienced greater electoral competition than places left in relatively stable representative arrangements. The next question is whether that competitive disruption altered who actually remained in Parliament.

6.3 Elite Persistence and Geographic Adaptation

The preceding analyses show that reform reorganized both the geography of representation and the competitive environments attached to it. I now ask what that reorganization meant for the politicians who occupied the pre-reform system. The relevant theoretical distinction is not simply between elite persistence and elite displacement. Geographic reform may disrupt political careers by depreciating resources tied to a particular constituency while leaving other resources—experience, status, networks, wealth, and the ability to secure representation elsewhere—largely intact. I examine this possibility by following the 487 MPs representing English constituencies in 1831 into the parliaments returned after reform.⁴³

⁴³Because the individual-level sources on the two sides of reform use different naming and biographical conventions, persistence is measured using a reviewed cross-source linkage rather than assuming that

Figure 8: MP persistence across adjacent English parliaments



Notes: For each pair of adjacent parliaments, the figure reports the share of MPs representing English constituencies in the first parliament who also represent an English constituency in the next. The vertical line marks the Great Reform Act. The comparison measures persistence anywhere in the English parliamentary system rather than retention of a particular constituency.

The first post-reform parliament produced a substantial break in incumbent continuity. Only 53% of the 1831 cohort returned to an English constituency in 1833. But immediate disappearance was not equivalent to permanent exit: fifty-seven MPs who were absent in 1833 subsequently returned, so that 64% of the original cohort appeared at least once between 1833 and 1841. Figure 8 places that break against ordinary parliament-to-parliament persistence in the surrounding period.

The comparison makes clear that 1832 produced a disruption rather than a new equilibrium of unusually low elite persistence. The 1831–1833 transition falls sharply below the surrounding historical pattern, but persistence subsequently returns to its earlier range. Reform therefore interrupted established political careers without simply inaugurating a permanently higher rate of elite turnover. That distinction is important for the theory: a geographic reorganization can destroy the value of existing political positions while leaving many of the politicians who held them capable of adapting.

The disruption was also concentrated where reform most directly altered the incumbent’s representative geography. Table 7 reports persistence according to what happened to an

source-specific person identifiers are continuous across 1832. The persistence analysis is restricted to England. The baseline cohort consists of MPs representing English constituencies in 1831, and persistence is measured by subsequent representation of an English constituency. An MP who subsequently represented only a Welsh, Scottish, or Irish constituency is therefore treated as exiting the English parliamentary system.

Table 7: MP persistence by the reform type of the incumbent's 1831 constituency

	Returned in 1833	Returned at least once by 1841	Num. of MPs
No listed change	0.69 (0.47)	0.79 (0.41)	86
Representation reduced	0.50 (0.58)	0.50 (0.58)	4
Representation increased	0.80 (0.41)	0.80 (0.41)	15
Enlarged to parish	0.46 (0.50)	0.60 (0.49)	100
Enlarged to modern town	0.59 (0.49)	0.71 (0.45)	118
County divided	0.81 (0.40)	0.83 (0.38)	52
Constituency abolished	0.22 (0.42)	0.38 (0.49)	112

Notes: The table shows descriptive persistence for the sample of MPs who represented English constituencies in 1831. Entries in the first two columns are the share of MPs who subsequently represented an English constituency, with standard deviations in parentheses. The final column reports the number of 1831 MPs in each reform category.

MP's 1831 constituency.

The ordering is revealing. MPs whose constituencies disappeared were by far the least likely to survive the first post-reform parliament, whereas MPs from unchanged constituencies and divided counties were much more likely to remain. Parish enlargement also coincides with comparatively low persistence. Because the allocation of these reforms was itself politically and demographically structured, these differences are not causal estimates of reform type. They nevertheless locate the break in political careers where the map was being most substantially remade. The institutional reorganization of representation and the disruption of incumbent careers were therefore closely connected.

One reason is that reform changed the conditions under which incumbents had to defend those careers. Among MPs whose old named constituency survived, Table 8 compares persistence according to whether the first post-reform election was contested, conditioning on the constituency's pre-reform competitive history and its form of reform.

Incumbents attached to constituencies that became competitive after reform were substantially less likely both to return somewhere in England and to retain their old named constituency. The estimated differences are roughly sixteen to eighteen percentage points. I do not interpret this as evidence that competition mechanically *defeated* particular in-

Table 8: Post-reform electoral competition and incumbent persistence

	Returned to an English seat, 1833	Returned in same named seat, 1833
	(1)	(2)
First post-reform election contested	-0.16** (0.064)	-0.19*** (0.066)
Prior electoral competition	✓	✓
Reform-type controls	✓	✓
Nations	England	England
Years	1833	1833
Obsv	319	318

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: OLS regressions with standard errors clustered by the MP's 1831 constituency. The sample is restricted to MPs whose named 1831 constituency survives into the first post-reform parliament. The dependent variable in column (1) indicates whether the MP returned to any English constituency in 1833; column (2) indicates whether the MP returned to the same named English constituency. The key explanatory variable indicates whether the first post-reform election in the surviving 1831 constituency was contested. Models control for the constituency's pre-reform share of contested returns and for the form of reform experienced by the 1831 constituency. The estimates are descriptive associations and do not distinguish an incumbent who stood and lost from one who chose not to stand.

cumbents, because the data do not yet distinguish MPs who stood and lost from those who chose not to stand. The result instead connects the two political consequences of the new geography: where reform produced a more competitive electoral environment, incumbent persistence was also lower.

Yet persistence did not require preservation of an incumbent's original geographic base. Among the MPs who returned immediately after reform, a substantial minority did so somewhere else; and among the twenty-five immediate survivors whose 1831 constituency had been abolished, twenty-four represented a constituency in a different county. Abolition therefore provides the clearest case in which continued parliamentary service required geographic adaptation rather than simple retention of an existing position.

This is also the setting in which the theory's distinction between geographically specific and portable political resources is most demanding. Once an incumbent's constituency disappears, resources whose value depends on that particular electoral relationship should depreciate sharply. Resources that can be carried across places should matter more. Table 9 examines this possibility among MPs exposed to abolition, using prior service in multiple counties as an indicator that an MP had already demonstrated an ability to obtain representation across distinct geographic settings.

The association is remarkably stable across specifications. MPs with prior cross-county experience were substantially more likely to return both immediately and at some point through 1841, and the relationship changes little after accounting for parliamentary expe-

Table 9: MP resources and parliamentary persistence after the Great Reform Act for MPs in abolished constituencies

	Returned in 1833			Returned at least once by 1841		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Prior service in multiple counties	0.23*** (0.072)	0.22*** (0.069)	0.23*** (0.077)	0.26*** (0.088)	0.23** (0.093)	0.24** (0.10)
Pre-reform parliaments served	-0.040*** (0.013)	-0.035** (0.015)	-0.033** (0.016)	-0.046*** (0.016)	-0.035 (0.022)	-0.026 (0.023)
Aristocrat		0.36** (0.15)	0.38** (0.16)		0.25 (0.15)	0.28* (0.16)
Baronet		-0.67** (0.31)	-0.67** (0.31)		-0.38 (0.25)	-0.40 (0.26)
Gentry		0.73*** (0.14)	0.72*** (0.15)		0.60*** (0.15)	0.62*** (0.16)
Family parliamentary service		0.00066 (0.049)	-0.017 (0.070)		-0.098 (0.077)	-0.17 (0.11)
Landed interest		0.17* (0.087)	0.12 (0.096)		0.100 (0.14)	0.074 (0.15)
Capital interest		0.039 (0.079)	0.016 (0.088)		0.12 (0.079)	0.10 (0.086)
Residence tied to 1831 seat			-0.0070 (0.13)			0.10 (0.17)
Obsv	112	112	96	112	112	96
Mean of DV	0.22	0.22	0.23	0.38	0.38	0.39
SD of DV	0.42	0.42	0.42	0.49	0.49	0.49
R-squared	0.085	0.220	0.246	0.084	0.162	0.179

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: OLS regressions with standard errors clustered by the MP's 1831 constituency. The sample consists of MPs whose 1831 English constituency was abolished by the Great Reform Act. The dependent variable in columns (1)–(3) indicates whether the MP represented an English constituency in 1833; the dependent variable in columns (4)–(6) indicates whether the MP represented an English constituency at least once between 1833 and 1841. The prior service measure is an indicator for whether the MP had represented English constituencies located in more than one county before reform. All specifications control for the number of pre-reform English parliaments in which the MP served. The residence measure is available for 96 of the 112 MPs in the abolition sample due to the difficulty of geolocating some residences.

rience and a broader set of social and political resources. Adding a measure of residence tied to the old constituency also leaves the portability relationship largely unchanged, while local rootedness itself has little association with persistence. The relevant contrast is therefore not simply between locally embedded and unembedded politicians. What appears to matter is whether an incumbent possessed resources that had already proved usable outside a single geographic base.⁴⁴

Taken together, these results qualify both a simple displacement account and a simple continuity account of democratization. Reform produced an unusually large break in

⁴⁴A comparison with MPs from constituencies experiencing no listed change provides weaker evidence that portability mattered *especially* under abolition. The interaction between prior multi-county service and abolition is positive for both immediate and eventual persistence, but imprecisely estimated. I therefore treat these results as evidence about heterogeneity among politicians exposed to the common severe shock of abolition, rather than as evidence that geographic portability mattered uniquely under abolition.

incumbent persistence, particularly where the representative map changed most and where post-reform electoral environments became competitive. But it did not erase the resources on which elite political careers rested. Persistence soon returned to its historical range, some initially displaced MPs re-entered parliament, and many survivors reconstructed careers outside their former geographic bases. The Great Reform Act therefore changed the conditions under which incumbent elites competed for office more decisively than it changed the identity of the political class itself.

7 Conclusion

The Great Reform Act is conventionally understood as a moment when the boundaries of political participation changed. This paper suggests that another consequential set of boundaries was *geographic*. Reform redistributed political voice not only by changing who could vote, but by deciding which places would possess representation, which populations would be represented together, and how much parliamentary weight those populations would receive. Seen in this way, representative geography was not an administrative detail of democratization. It was one of the institutional forms through which democratization occurred.

That perspective changes how the politics of reform itself should be understood. The electoral map enacted in 1832 was neither a mechanical translation of population into representation nor simply an exercise in incumbent protection. Demographic change made some inherited arrangements increasingly difficult to defend, while political power shaped the choices available within those constraints. Existing interests could adapt a constituency rather than preserve it unchanged, accommodate a new representational principle while protecting some of the resources on which their influence rested, or accept losses on one geographic margin while remaining politically viable elsewhere. Consequently, endogenous institutional design need not imply the absence of meaningful institutional change.

The consequences of reform reinforce that point. The political system that shaped the new geography did not thereby insulate incumbent politicians from its consequences. The paper shows that reorganization was associated with greater electoral challenge, and the sharpest geographic disruptions coincided with unusually large interruptions in incumbent careers. Yet disruption did not imply a wholesale replacement. Many incumbents returned, sometimes only after an absence and often through constituencies far removed from those they had previously represented. What persisted, in other words, was not necessarily the old political arrangement. Frequently it was the politician.

This distinction helps reconcile two views of democratization that can otherwise appear contradictory. Berlinski, Dewan and Coppenolle (2014), studying later British franchise

reforms while deliberately holding changes in constituency boundaries and parliamentary seats aside, find little evidence that franchise extension alone immediately displaced aristocratic elites. The results here complement that finding by examining the institutional margin their design excludes: the reconstruction of representative geography itself. Even where that geography changed substantially, political disruption and elite persistence could occur together. Elite continuity therefore need not demonstrate that reform was inconsequential. The relevant question is whether elites survive because their old advantages remain intact or because they possess resources that can be redeployed under new institutional conditions. The evidence is consistent with geographic reform reducing the value of political assets tied to particular constituencies while leaving other resources available for use elsewhere. Democratization may therefore transform the mechanisms through which elites survive rather than necessarily transforming the identity of the elite itself.

This also suggests a broader way of thinking about the relationship between social change and political development. Industrialization did not translate automatically into democratization. It altered the distribution of population and economic activity, thereby producing an increasingly visible mismatch between social geography and representative geography. Political reform mediated that mismatch by reconstructing the territorial institutions through which representation operated because contemporaries viewed this mismatch as meaningful and because popular pressure highlighted it. Representative geography is therefore one of the mechanisms through which long-run social transformation is converted into political change.

Nor was the geography created in 1832 necessarily an endpoint. Contemporaries understood that the settlement could itself generate new exclusions and new demands for reform. Lord Ellenborough worried that “in ten years the poorest class will be unrepresented & then we shall have a servile war or universal suffrage” (Bateman 2018, 256). His prediction was polemical, but the dynamic is important. Any geographic settlement fixes representation against a demographic and political landscape that can change. A central next question is therefore how long the representative geography created by one democratizing reform persists, when subsequent population and economic change renders it politically vulnerable again, and how incumbent politicians, parties, and other political organizations adapt across successive rounds of institutional reconstruction.

References

- Acemoglu, Daron and James A. Robinson. 2000. "Why Did the West Extend the Franchise? Growth, Inequality and Democracy in Historical Perspective." *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 115(4):1167–1199.
- Acemoglu, Daron and James A. Robinson. 2006. *Economic Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy*. New York, NY: Cambridge University Press.
- Acemoglu, Daron and James A. Robinson. 2008. "Persistence of Power, Elites, and Institutions." *The American Economic Review* 98(1):267 – 293.
- Aidt, Toke and Gabriel Leon-Ablan. 2023. "Can Democratic Reforms Promote Political Activism?" *Working Paper* .
- Aidt, Toke S. and Raphael Franck. 2015. "Democratization Under the Threat of Revolution: Evidence from the Great Reform Act of 1832." *Econometrica* 83(2):505–547.
- Aidt, Toke S. and Raphael Franck. 2019. "What Motivates an Oligarchic Elite to Democratize? Evidence from the Roll Call Vote on the Great Reform Act of 1832." *Journal of Economic History* 79(3):773–825.
- Aidt, Toke S and Raphael Franck. 2025. *Peaceful and Violent Origins of Voting Rights: A Political Economy Analysis of the Great Reform Act of 1832*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press.
- Albertus, Michael and Victor Menaldo. 2018. *Authoritarianism and the Elite Origins of Democracy*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
- Baseheart, H and J Comer. 1991. "Partisan and incumbent effects in state legislative redistricting." *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 66.
- Bateman, David A. 2018. *Disenfranchising Democracy*. New York, NY: Cambridge University Press.
- Beramendi, Pablo. 2012. *The Political Geography of Inequality: Regions and Redistribution*. New York, NY: Cambridge University Press.
- Berlinski, Samuel, Torun Dewan and Brenda van Coppenolle. 2014. "Franchise Extension and the British Aristocracy." *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 34(4):531–558.
- Brock, Michael. 1973. *The Great Reform Act*. HarperCollins Publishers Ltd HarperCollins Publishers Ltd.
- Cain, Bruce E. 1984. *The Reapportionment Puzzle*. Berkeley, CA: University of California Press.
- Cain, Bruce E. 1985. "Assessing the partisan effects of redistricting." *American Political Science Review* 79:320–333.
- calvo, ERnesto and Jonathan Rodden. 2015. "The Achilles heel of plurality systems: geography and representation in multiparty democracies." *American Journal of Political Science* 59.

- Cannon, John. 1972. *Parliamentary Reform 1640-1832*. New York, NY: Cambridge University Press.
- Carson, JL and MH Crespín. 2004. "The effect of state redistricting methods on electoral competition in United States House of Representatives races." *State Politics and Policy Quarterly* 14(4):144.
- Chen, Jowei and Jonathan Rodden. 2013. "Unintentional gerrymandering: political geography and electoral bias in legislatures." *Quarterly Journal of Political Science* 8.
- Clark, J.C.D. 1985. *English Society, 1688-1832*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
- Cox, Gary, Adriane Fresh and Sebastian Saiegh. 2023. "The Political Economy of the Great Reform Act." *Journal of Historical Political Economy* 3:65–93.
- Cox, Gary W. 1997. *Making Votes Count: Strategic Coordination in the World's Electoral Systems*. New York, NY: Cambridge University Press.
- Cox, Gary W. 2005. *The Efficient Secret*. New York, NY: Cambridge University Press.
- Cox, Gary W. and Jonathan N. Katz. 2002. *Elbridge Gerry's Salamander: The Electoral Consequences of the Reapportionment Revolution*. New York, NY: Cambridge University Press.
- Davis, Richard W. 1976. "Deference and Aristocracy in the Time of the Great Reform Act." *The American Historical Review* 81(3):532–539.
- Desposato, SW and JR Petrocick. 2003. "The variable incumbency advantage: new voters, redistricting, and the personal vote." *American Journal of Political Science* 72.
- Dewan, Torun, Jaakko Meriläinen and Janne Tukiainen. 2020. "Victorian Voting: The Origins of Party Orientation and Class Alignment." *American Journal of Political Science* 64(4):869–886.
- Dod, Charles Roger and Robert Phipps Dod. 1908. *Dod's parliamentary companion*. Cambridge University Press Cambridge University Press.
URL: <http://bks1.books.google.com/books?id=k1ANAAAYAAJ&printsec=frontcover&img=1&zoom>
- Downs, Anthony. 1957. *An Economic Theory of Democracy*. Harper New York: NY: Harper.
- Eddie, CA. 1970. "Charles II, the Commons and the Newark Charter Dispute: The Crown's Last Attempt to Enfranchise a Borough." *Journal of British Studies* 10(1):49–68.
- Eggers, Andrew E and Arthur Spirling. 2014. "Electoral Security as a Determinant of Legislator Activity, 1832-1918: New Data and Methods for Analyzing British Political Development." *Legislative Studies Quarterly* 34(4).
- Ellis, Harold A. 1979. "Aristocratic Influence and Electoral Independence: The Whig Model of Parliamentary Reform 1792-1832." *The Journal of Modern History* 51(S4):D1251–D1276.

- Engstrom, EJ. 2013. *Partisan Gerrymandering and the Construction of American Democracy*. Ann Arbor, MI: Michigan University Press.
- Evans, Eric J. 1994. *The Great Reform Act of 1832*. New York, NY: Routledge.
- Fisher, David. 2009. *The History of Parliament: The House of Commons 1820–1832*. Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press.
- Fresh, Adriane. 2024. “Population and Political Change in Industrial Britain.” *SSRN Working Paper* .
URL: https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=4734362
- Fresh, Adriane. 2025. “Elite Persistence in the Era of England’s Expanding Overseas Trade.” *Comparative Political Studies (forthcoming)* .
URL: https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=4721401
- Gash, Norman. 1953. *Politics in the Age of Peel: A Study in the Technique of Parliamentary Representation, 1830-1850*. London, UK: Longmans, Green, and Co.
- Geddes, Barbara. 1999. “What do we know about democratization after twenty years.” *Annual Review of Political Science* 2(1):115–144.
- Hanham, Harold John. 1959. *Elections and Party Management*. Longmans New York, NY: Longmans.
- HPP. 2013. “History of Parliament Online.”
URL: <http://www.historyofparliamentonline.org/>
- Keibek, Sebastian A.J. 2017. “Allocating Labourers to Occupation (Sub-)Setors Using Regression Techniques.” *CGHPSS Working Paper No 27* .
URL: https://www.econsoc.hist.cam.ac.uk/docs/CWPESH_number_2_Marc_2017.pdf
- Kitson, P, G Newton, Max Satchell, Leigh Shaw-Taylor, E A Wrigley and T Wrigley. 2010. *1817 Estimated Census of Adult Male Occupations for England Wales in 1851 Registration Districts (Database)*. Cambridge, UK: Cambridge Group for the History of Population and Social Structure.
- Laski, Harold. 1928. “The Personnel of the English Cabinet, 1801-1928.” *American Political Science Review* 22(1):12–31.
- Law, C M. 1967. “The Growth of Urban Population in England and Wales, 1801-1911.” *Transactions of the Institute of British Geographers* 41.
- Lees, Andrew and Lynn Hollen Lees. 2007. *Cities and the Making of Modern Europe, 1750-1914*. New York, NY: Cambridge University Press.
- Levitan, Kathrin. 2011. *A Cultural History of the British Census. Envisioning the Multitude in the Nineteenth Century*. New York, NY: Palgrave MacMillan.
- Lipset, Seymour Martin. 1960. *Political Man*. New York, NY: Doubleday & Company Inc.

- Lizzeri, Alessandro and Nicola Persico. 2004. “Why Did the Elites Extend the Suffrage? Democracy and the Scope of Government, with an Application to Britain’s “Age of Reform”.” *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 119(2):707.
- McGhee, Eric. 2020. “Partisan Gerrymandering and Political Science.” *Annual Review of Political Science* 23(1):171–185.
- Moore, David Cresap. 1976. *The Politics of Deference: A Study in the Mid-Nineteenth Century English Political System*. Hassocks, UK: Harvester Press.
- O’Gorman, Frank. 1989. *Voters, Patrons, and Parties*. Clarendon Press Clarendon Press.
- Paine, Thomas. 1984. *The Rights of Man [1791]*. New York, NY: Penguin Books.
- Palfrey, Thomas R. 1984. “Spatial Equilibrium with Entry.” *The Review of Economic Studies* 51(1):139–156.
- Perkin, Harold. 1985. *The Origins of Modern English Society*. New York, NY: Ark Paperbacks.
- Philbin, J. Holladay. 1965. *Parliamentary Representation, 1832: England and Wales*.
- Phillips, John A. 1982. *Electoral Behavior in Unreformed England*. Princeton University Press Princeton University Press.
- Porritt, Edward. 1903. *The Unreformed House of Commons*. Vol. 1.
- Przeworski, Adam. 1991. *Democracy and the Market*. Cambridge University Press Cambridge University Press.
- Rehfeld, A. 2005. *The Concept of Constituency*. Cambridge, MA: Cambridge University Press.
- Robson, Brian. 2014. “Maps and mathematics: ranking the English boroughs for the 1832 Reform Act.” *Journal of Historical Geography* 46:66–79.
- Rueschemeyer, Dietrich, Evelyn Huber Stephens and John D Stephens. 1992. *Capitalist Development and Democracy*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
- Seymour, Charles M. A. 1970. *Electoral Reform in England and Wales: The Development and Operation of the Parliamentary Franchise, 1832-1885 [1915]*. New Haven, CT: Archon Books.
- Shaw-Taylor, Leigh, Max Satchell, T Wrigley and G Newton. 2015. *1801 to 1891 Census Report England Wales Parish Registration District Population (Database)*. Cambridge, UK: Cambridge Group for the History of Population and Social Structure.
- Smith, Henry Stooks. 1973. *The Parliaments of England*. Chichester, UK: Political Reference Publications.
- Southall, Humphrey. 2005. *Great Britain Historical Database*. Portsmouth, UK: University of Portsmouth.
URL: hds.essex.ac.uk/gbhd

- Spychal, Martin. 2024. *Mapping the State: English Boundaries and the 1832 Reform Act*. London, UK: University of London Press.
- Thompson, Stephen. 2011. “Redrawing the boundaries of British democracy? Census data and the Great Reform Act, 1832-2011.” *History and Policy* 110.
- Whitehead, Laurence. 2002. *Democratization: Theory and Experience*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press.
- Wrigley, E A. 2010. “PST system of classifying occupations.” *Cambridge Group for the History of Population and Social Structure* .
- Wrigley, E Anthony and R.S. Schofield. 1989. *The Population History of England 1541-1871: A reconstruction*. New York, NY: Cambridge University Press.
- Ziblatt, Daniel. 2017. *Conservative Parties and the Birth of Democracy*. New York, NY: Cambridge University Press.

Appendices

A Constituencies and Their Boundary Changes

Table A1 includes the sample of constituencies enfranchised on the eve of the Great Reform Act. It describes their area, their type, and what happened to them as part of reform. Some constituencies are small enough that their area, given the tolerance of the one decimal place measure, are given as zero.

Table A1: Constituencies on the eve of the Great Reform Act

Constituency	Type	Nation	Rep. Decreased	Rep. Increased	Disen- franchised	Split County	Extended to Town	Extended to Parishes	No Change	Area sq. km
Abingdon	B	E							✓	1.36
Aldborough	B	E			✓					8.97
Aldeburgh	B	E			✓					6.54
Amersham	B	E							✓	24.56
Andover	B	E					✓			39.37
Appleby	B	E			✓					5.79
Arundel	B	E	2 to 1							8.21
Ashburton	B	E	2 to 1					✓		28.04
Aylesbury	B	E						✓		263.07
Banbury	B	E						✓		0.37
Barnstaple	B	E					✓			6.89
Bath	B	E					✓			1.04
Bedford	B	E							✓	8.91
Bedfordshire	C	E							✓	619.47
Bere Alston	B	E			✓					24.45
Berkshire	C	E		2 to 3						180.76
Berwick	B	E					✓			22.58
Beverley	B	E							✓	9.98
Bewdley	B	E						✓		8.45
Bishop's Castle	B	E			✓					7.36
Bletchingly	B	E			✓					22.63
Bodmin	B	E						✓		10.50
Boroughbridge	B	E			✓					0.55
Bossiney	B	E			✓					18.13
Boston	B	E					✓			36.05
Brackley	B	E			✓					3.07
Bramber	B	E			✓					3.49
Bridgnorth	B	E						✓		6.26
Bridgwater	B	E					✓			0.69
Bridport	B	E					✓			0.44
Bristol	B	E					✓			2.82
Buckingham	B	E						✓		19.81
Buckinghamshire	C	E		2 to 3						161.02
Bury St. Edmunds	B	E							✓	11.68
Callington	B	E			✓					10.42
Calne	B	E	2 to 1					✓		3.86
Cambridge	B	E							✓	12.79
Cambridge U	U	E							✓	0.04
Cambridgeshire	C	E		2 to 3						220.48
Camelford	B	E			✓					14.35
Canterbury	B	E					✓			9.03
Carlisle	B	E					✓			0.23
Castle Rising	B	E			✓					8.97
Cheshire	C	E				✓				272.99
Chester	B	E					✓			12.43
Chichester	B	E					✓			1.55
Chippenham	B	E						✓		0.11
Christchurch	B	E	2 to 1					✓		1.75
Cirencester	B	E						✓		0.22
City Of London	B	E							✓	3.01
City of York	B	E						✓		7.86
Clitheroe	B	E	2 to 1					✓		8.56
Co Durham	C	E				✓				265.31
Cockermouth	B	E						✓		17.26
Colchester	B	E							✓	47.49
Corfe Castle	B	E			✓					36.27
Cornwall	C	E				✓				100.19

Notes: Table continued on the next page.

Table A2: (continued) Constituencies on the eve of the Great Reform Act

Constituency	Type	Nation	Rep. Decreased	Rep. Increased	Disen- franchised	Split County	Extended to Town	Extended to Parishes	No Change	Area sq. km
Coventry	B	E							✓	22.20
Cricklade	B	E						✓		574.95
Cumberland	C	E				✓				406.05
Dartmouth	B	E	2 to 1				✓			8.16
Derby	B	E							✓	7.22
Derbyshire	C	E				✓				265.87
Devizes	B	E					✓			2.50
Devonshire	C	E				✓				429.08
Dorchester	B	E					✓			0.28
Dorsetshire	C	E		2 to 3						259.04
Dover	CP	E					✓			4.55
Downton	B	E			✓					50.36
Droitwich	B	E	2 to 1					✓		5.49
Dunwich	B	E			✓					5.08
Durham City	B	E					✓			1.34
East Grinstead	B	E			✓					61.71
East Looe	B	E			✓					0.29
East Retford	B	E						✓		839.54
Essex	C	E				✓				427.09
Evesham	B	E							✓	9.51
Exeter	B	E					✓			6.16
Eye	B	E	2 to 1							15.75
Fowey	B	E			✓					8.00
Gatton	B	E			✓					5.31
Gloucester	B	E					✓			1.08
Gloucestershire	C	E				✓				331.19
Grantham	B	E						✓		0.38
Great Bedwyn	B	E			✓					45.93
Great Grimsby	B	E	2 to 1					✓		7.95
Great Marlow	B	E							✓	0.76
Great Yarmouth	B	E					✓			11.39
Guildford	B	E					✓			0.27
Hampshire	C	E				✓				422.02
Harwich	B	E							✓	6.99
Haslemere	B	E			✓					1.04
Hastings	CP	E							✓	8.58
Hedon	B	E			✓					1.28
Helstone	B	E	2 to 1					✓		0.53
Hereford	B	E							✓	20.71
Herefordshire	C	E		2 to 3						210.02
Hertford	B	E					✓			3.30
Hertfordshire	C	E		2 to 3						164.28
Heytesbury	B	E			✓					21.07
High Wycombe	B	E							✓	0.48
Higham Ferrers	B	E			✓					7.46
Hindon	B	E			✓					1.03
Honiton	B	E						✓		0.43
Horsham	B	E	2 to 1					✓		0.66
Hull	B	E							✓	0.34
Huntingdon	B	E						✓		4.42
Huntingdonshire	C	E							✓	953.44
Hythe	CP	E	2 to 1					✓		9.15
Ilchester	B	E			✓					2.85
Ipswich	B	E							✓	33.38
Kent	C	E				✓				412.82
Kings Lynn	B	E							✓	12.76
Kingston	B	E					✓			0.00
Knaresborough	B	E					✓			0.31
Lancashire	C	E				✓				532.13
Lancaster	B	E					✓			6.75
Launceston	B	E	2 to 1					✓		6.58
Leicester	B	E					✓			1.30
Leicestershire	C	E				✓				213.77
Leominster	B	E						✓		32.55
Lewes	B	E					✓			0.47
Lichfield	B	E							✓	13.64

Notes: Table continued on the next page.

Table A3: (continued) Constituencies on the eve of the Great Reform Act

Constituency	Type	Nation	Rep. Decreased	Rep. Increased	Disen- franchised	Split County	Extended to Town	Extended to Parishes	No Change	Area sq. km
Lincoln	B	E							✓	15.29
Lincolnshire	C	E				✓				706.83
Liskeard	B	E	2 to 1					✓		9.79
Liverpool	B	E					✓			7.18
Lostwithiel	B	E			✓					0.47
Ludgershall	B	E			✓					7.26
Ludlow	B	E					✓			5.88
Lyme Regis	B	E	2 to 1				✓			0.62
Lymington	B	E					✓			0.81
Maidstone	B	E							✓	18.42
Maldon	B	E						✓		15.36
Malmesbury	B	E	2 to 1					✓		0.45
Malton	B	E						✓		28.56
Marlborough	B	E							✓	0.56
Middlesex	C	E							✓	716.50
Midhurst	B	E	2 to 1					✓		2.23
Milborne Port	B	E			✓					13.48
Minehead	B	E			✓					16.20
Mitchell	B	E			✓					33.75
Morpeth	B	E	2 to 1					✓		0.94
Much Wenlock	B	E							✓	196.41
New Romney	CP	E			✓					9.22
New Shoreham	B	E						✓		495.93
New Windsor	B	E					✓			10.98
New Woodstock	B	E	2 to 1					✓		0.26
Newark Upon Trent	B	E							✓	8.13
Newcastle (UL)	B	E							✓	2.46
Newcastle (UT)	B	E					✓			8.57
Newport (Cornwall)	B	E			✓					16.53
Newport I.O.W.	B	E					✓			0.39
Newton (Lancashire)	B	E			✓					25.31
Newton I.O.W.	B	E			✓					1.12
Norfolk	C	E				✓				536.10
Northallerton	B	E	2 to 1					✓		42.53
Northampton	B	E							✓	5.33
Northamptonshire	C	E				✓				255.36
Northumberland	C	E				✓				527.39
Norwich	B	E							✓	36.11
Nottingham	B	E							✓	8.02
Nottinghamshire	C	E				✓				133.98
Okehampton	B	E			✓					53.06
Old Sarum	B	E			✓					0.29
Orford	B	E			✓					10.83
Oxford	B	E					✓			10.96
Oxford University	U	E		2 to 3					✓	0.04
Oxfordshire	C	E								200.13
Penryn	B	E					✓			2.02
Petersborough	B	E						✓		6.17
Petersfield	B	E	2 to 1					✓		0.97
Plymouth	B	E					✓			5.89
Plymton Erle	B	E			✓					1.06
Pontefract	B	E					✓			11.04
Poole	B	E					✓			0.87
Portsmouth	B	E					✓			26.07
Preston	B	E					✓			8.27
Queenborough	B	E			✓					1.15
Reading	B	E							✓	10.12
Reigate	B	E	2 to 1					✓		0.16
Richmond	B	E						✓		32.89
Ripon	B	E							✓	6.48
Rochester	B	E					✓			11.07
Rutlandshire	C	E							✓	394.78
Rye	CP	E	2 to 1					✓		85.33
Salisbury	B	E					✓			0.64
Saltash	B	E			✓					0.81
Sandwich	CP	E					✓			2.81
Scarborough	B	E							✓	13.18

Notes: Table continued on the next page.

Table A4: (continued) Constituencies on the eve of the Great Reform Act

Constituency	Type	Nation	Rep. Decreased	Rep. Increased	Disen- franchised	Split County	Extended to Town	Extended to Parishes	No Change	Area sq. km
Steyning	B	E			✓					13.66
Stockbridge	B	E			✓					4.41
Sudbury	B	E					✓			3.95
Suffolk	C	E				✓				380.75
Surrey	C	E				✓				193.43
Sussex	C	E				✓				312.79
Tamworth	B	E						✓		0.66
Taunton	B	E					✓			0.25
Tavistock	B	E						✓		1.25
Tewkesbury	B	E						✓		0.15
Thetford	B	E							✓	28.70
Thirsk	B	E	2 to 1					✓		47.27
Tiverton	B	E							✓	72.81
Totnes	B	E					✓			0.69
Tregony	B	E			✓					0.63
Truro	B	E					✓			2.01
Wallingford	B	E	2 to 1					✓		1.50
Wareham	B	E	2 to 1					✓		3.61
Warwick	B	E							✓	23.01
Warwickshire	C	E				✓				224.76
Wells	B	E					✓			3.01
Wendover	B	E			✓					23.16
Weobley	B	E							✓	13.33
West Looe	B	E			✓					0.57
Westbury	B	E	2 to 1					✓		0.09
Westminster	B	E							✓	10.77
Westmorland	C	E							✓	203.30
Weymouth	B	E	4 to 2				✓			1.65
Whitchurch	B	E			✓					25.86
Wigan	B	E							✓	8.33
Wilton	B	E						✓		0.47
Wiltshire	C	E				✓				281.21
Winchelsea	CP	E			✓					4.24
Winchester	B	E					✓			0.98
Wootton Bassett	B	E			✓					20.57
Worcester	B	E						✓		1.17
Worcestershire	C	E							✓	194.11
Yarmouth	B	E			✓					0.27
Yorkshire	C	E				✓				1190.47

Notes: The table presents information of the sample of constituencies in England (nation is “E”) that were enfranchised on the eve of the 1832 Great Reform Act. The constituency types are: B borough, C county, CP cinque port, and U university. The area is approximate and some constituencies were sufficiently small, or has such limited notion of a geography that they appear as having zero area based on this measurement in square kilometers with two decimal points. No change is a category that indicates that boundaries mostly remained the same. For boroughs this is true; for counties they may have had boroughs within that were enfranchised or disenfranchised and so their total area and population changed somewhat even if their outer boundary remained the same. If looking up a constituency name, recall that many had multiple names, spelling variations or idiosyncracies (e.g., Woodstock versus New Woodstock).

B Examples of Topics in Parliamentary Debates on Democratic Reform Prior to 1832

To understand how reform topics were discussed, I had-coded reform debates. To do so, I worked at the sentence level. Sentences were first coded as either substantively related to parliamentary reform or procedural or rhetorical in nature. Substantive sentences were then classified into topical categories, including geographic representation, constitutional principles, suffrage, patronage and political influence, public opinion and popular demand, and public order.

Geographic representation was the most frequently discussed topic (50%), substantially exceeding discussion of suffrage (10%). By contrast, despite the prominence of revolutionary threats in much of the historical literature, questions of public order were among the least frequently discussed substantive topics. See also Cox, Fresh and Saiegh (2023).

This appendix presents a selection of reform debate quotations that illustrate the different categories. The category of geographic representation concerns questions about the boundaries of constituencies. The influence category includes discussions of patronage, elite dominance, and corruption. The order category includes discussions of revolutionary threads, riots, order and stability. The franchise category includes discussions of the nature of electoral requirements. The category of constitutional principles includes broad debates, often normative, about what representation meant. Other smaller categories—institutional procedures and forms, political strategy, religion, etc.—are excluded from the table. Not all sentences in the debates were topically about the nature of reform either.

Table B1: Examples of topics in parliamentary debates on reform

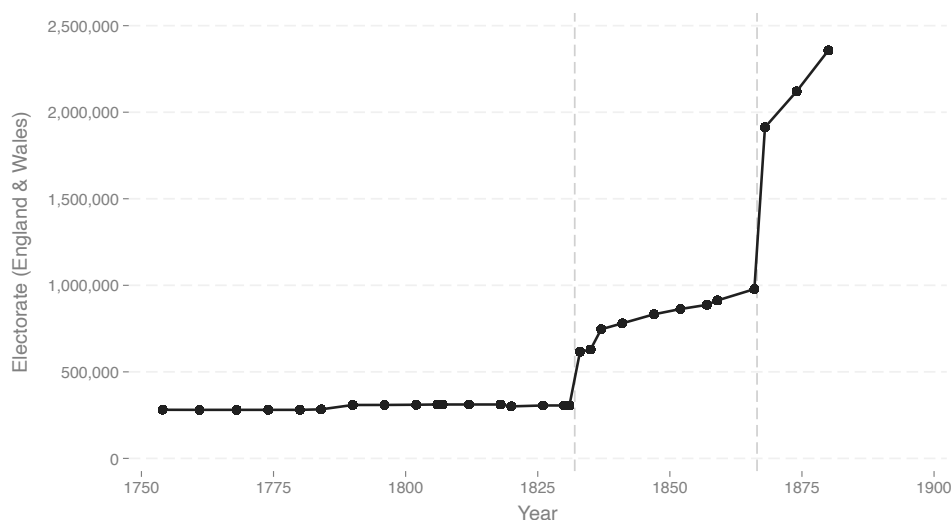
Category	Date	Speaker	Example quotation
Geographic representation	2 Aug. 1831	Lord Milton	“Nevertheless, he would vote to take Sudbury out of the schedule, because he thought there was a sufficient connexion with that borough, and the hamlet of Ballingdon, to justify him in calling it part of Sudbury.”
Influence	26 Feb. 1831	Mr. John Wood	“That family had said, that they would keep the present Member in till a certain noble Lord came of age, and that then he should take his seat for that borough in Parliament.”
Order	2 Aug. 1831	Mr. Hunt	“He begged to call the attention of the Committee to what had transpired upwards of ten years ago, at Manchester.”
Franchise	7 Feb. 1832	Sir Charles Wetherell	“But when a person changed his residence four or five times during that term, he must prove that all his successive occupations were of 10l. value before he could obtain a vote.”
Constitutional principles	—	Sir Francis Burdett	“It has been held, that whilst the forms of the Constitution remained there was something so excellent in the mere forms, that not only was the possession of them of the highest value, but a hope was thereby justified of an amelioration of the state of the country.”

Notes: Examples are drawn from a random sample of sentences coded from Hansard reform debates. Categories correspond to the principal substantive topics identified in the coding exercise.

C Expansion of the Electorate

Figure C1 shows the trend in the overall size of the English (including Welsh) electorate both before and after the reform act. The size of the electorate before reform should itself be interpreted cautiously. Existing political interests could sometimes manipulate access to locally defined franchises. In corporation boroughs, for example, freemen could be strategically admitted to strengthen control of the electorate. At Bewdley, the corporation expanded the electorate three times between 1820 and 1832. Growth in the number of electors therefore did not necessarily imply that a constituency had become more politically open.

Figure C1: The total size of the electorate, England and Wales 1750-1884



Notes: The above plot presents the total size of the electorate in England and Wales. The vertical dashed lines are at the 1832 and 1867 Reform Acts. Data on the size of the electorate are collected from two sources. The first, pre-1832 is the History of Parliament Project constituency descriptions (HPP 2013). For the post-1832 period, I use the franchise data from Eggers and Spirling (2014). The post-1832 data is high quality given that the Great Reform Act helped to formalize franchise requirements and make electoral registration a new practice. The pre-1832 data is likely to include more measurement error given the lack of formalization of electoral practices like registration. Data on the electorate's size for this period comes, primarily, though not exclusively, from contests. Thus, estimates were not consistently obtained election-by-election if there was no contest. As a consequence, I interpolate the electorate's size for missing years, and do so with a simple linear interpolation. Of course, those who participate in voting in a contest are not the same as those who *could* have voted in the contest, another source of measurement error. However, because contests were still unusual affairs, and often inspired significant canvassing on the part of candidates and interest amongst the electorate, contests likely offer a good approximation of the electorate.

D By Election Results

By elections occurred when the initial parliamentary return required an additional election to be held. This could be because an MP was the holder of a hereditary title and was called the upper House (the senior holder of the title died and they inherited the seat in the House of Lords), or because an MP died, or because there was a dispute over the nature of the first parliamentary return. Though further measurement work could be done to separate out by elections that occur for reasons related-to or unrelated to election disputes, currently the by election measure combines them. Figure D1 shows the trend in by elections at the constituency level. There is no noticeable change in the immediate post-reform election.

Figure D1: Share of constituencies experiencing a by election by parliament during the early 19th century



Notes: The above plot presents the share of constituencies experiencing a by election in each parliament. By elections could be experiencing for a number of different reasons, including MPs who died in office, who were called to the House of Lords (granted a hereditary title, or their senior title holder died), or because of an electoral dispute including, but not limited to, a double return. Thus, by elections capture—with some measurement error—a different notion of a contest, which is a return that was somehow in dispute.

Unlike the contestation and challenger outcomes, by-elections exhibit little systematic relationship with the geography of reform (Figure D1). Constituencies experiencing different forms of territorial or representational change were generally no more or less likely to require a subsequent by-election than unchanged constituencies. This is consistent with the interpretation that reform primarily altered the competitiveness of elections themselves rather than broader patterns of dispute about elections. Because the current measure of by-elections includes occurrences for a variety of reasons the results should be interpreted with caution.

Table D1: The relationship between constituency representation changes in the Great Reform Act and the occurrence of a by election in the first post-reform election

	Pr(By Election)	
	(1)	(2)
Representation reduced	-0.042 (0.062)	-0.033 (0.064)
Representation increased	-0.17*** (0.060)	-0.028 (0.039)
New borough constituency	0.041 (0.088)	-0.0052 (0.091)
Split county	-0.027 (0.077)	0.12* (0.062)
Enlarged to parish	-0.071 (0.075)	-0.084 (0.076)
Enlarged to modern town	-0.036 (0.075)	-0.050 (0.076)
ln(Population)		0.034 (0.025)
Borough (=1)		0.25*** (0.068)
Region FE		✓
Nations	England	England
Years	1833 only	1833 only
Obsv	254	254
Mean of DV	0.14	0.14
SD of DV	0.35	0.35

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: OLS regressions. Robust standard errors in parentheses. The unit of analysis is the set of constituencies that existed in 1833 after the Great Reform Act. By elections are measured on the extensive margin, if at least one election occurred subsequent to the main election. The excluded category is constituencies that experienced no representation or boundary change. However, as noted in the text, this “no change” category should be interpreted with a modicum of caution because, for instance, counties with no changes in their main boundaries may *nevertheless* have had boroughs merged with them or carved out of them. See later tables for analyses that reflect these area and population changes.

E Population Weighted Parish Level Analysis

The parish level analysis in the main paper uses the parish as the unit of analysis, which asks: for *parishes*, how did the change between seats and population induced by representation and geographic boundary changes in 1832 create competition? One might be more interested in how these relationships reflect the experience of the population, given that malapportionment was still quite extreme. The below analysis asks how changes were experienced by the population. As the table illustrates, the results are not sensitive in sign or magnitude to this shift in weighting.

Table E1: The relationship between constituency representation changes in the Great Reform Act and electoral competition for all parishes, weighted by population

	Pr(Contest)		Number of Challengers	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Pop per MP decreased $\times$ post-1832	0.11 (0.074)	0.084 (0.078)	0.22* (0.12)	0.17 (0.12)
Pop per MP increased $\times$ post-1832	0.12 (0.087)	0.081 (0.089)	0.086 (0.16)	0.014 (0.17)
Parliament FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Parish FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Population weighted	✓	✓	✓	✓
Nations	England	England	England	England
Years	1802-1864	1802-1864	1802-1864	1802-1864
Obsv	8208	8208	8203	8203
Mean of DV (weighted)	0.37	0.37	0.50	0.50
SD of DV (weighted)	0.48	0.48	0.75	0.75

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: OLS regressions. Standard errors robust to clustering parishes together that share a unique representational history. The unit of analysis is the aggregated parish unit (see Section 4). Observations are weighted by 1802 population. Contests are measured on the extensive margin if there were more candidates running than seats available in the main (e.g., first) return for the parliament. That is, by elections are excluded. The number of challengers is measured as the number of candidates in excess of the number of seats available. Therefore, zero challengers is an uncontested election. The excluded category is parishes that were part of the same constituency before and after 1832 and thus their changes in population per MP are due only to population growth, not due to boundary changes. The excluded category consists of parishes experiencing no meaningful change in representation. These are parishes whose population per MP changed by less than 5% between the pre- and post-reform representative environments. The 5% threshold is intended to distinguish substantively meaningful changes in representation from minor fluctuations arising from population growth or the construction of historical geographic boundaries. Less than 1% of parish observations associated with extremely small reconstructed constituency populations, and therefore implausibly large values of population per MP, are excluded from the analysis.

F Excluding Clause 5 Boroughs

A number of boroughs served as precedents for the Grey Ministry as they contemplated reform. These were boroughs whose geographic area had been massively expanded in the late decades of the 18th century and the early decades of the 19th century. Each were cast as corrupt, and each had a small urban core with limited franchise that was substantially enlarged to many neighboring parishes. Table F1 lists and describes the changes to these constituencies. Because these boundaries were changed prior to 1832, they might contaminate the pre-1832 contestation estimation. To examine if this is the case, I estimate the parish level results without these boroughs. I also exclude the parishes of the borough of Grampound, the one constituency disenfranchised (again due to corruption) in the lead up to the Reform Act.

Table F1: Clause 5 boroughs extended to neighboring parishes prior to 1832

Constituency	Year	Nature of the Change
New Shoreham	1771	Enlarged to encompass the Rape of Bramber.
Cricklade	1782	Enlarged to the hundreds of Highworth, Cricklade, Staple & Kingsbridge.
Aylesbury	1802	Enlarged to the freeholders of hundreds of Aylesbury, Risborough, & Stone.
East Retford	1828	Enlarged to encompass the hundred of Bassetlaw.

Notes: Grampound was also changed during this period, being disenfranchised, but does not fit the Clause 5 definition and so is excluded from the table.

Figure F2 presents the results. The results are substantively similar to the baseline estimates. Point estimates remain positive and of comparable magnitude, indicating that the main findings are not driven by a handful of constituencies whose representative geography had already been altered prior to the Reform Act. Though the statistical significance of the population per MP decreased interaction does go away. Although this statistical significance is gone, the overall pattern remains consistent with the interpretation that changes in representation were associated with subsequent electoral competition.

Table F2: The relationship between constituency representation changes in the Great Reform Act and electoral competition for all parishes, without Clause 5 boroughs and Grampound

	Pr(Contest)		Number of Challengers	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Pop per MP decreased $\times$ post-1832	0.091 (0.069)	0.091 (0.070)	0.073 (0.096)	0.074 (0.098)
Pop per MP increased $\times$ post-1832	0.15** (0.072)	0.14* (0.073)	0.13 (0.093)	0.12 (0.094)
Parliament FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Parish FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Parish weighted	✓	✓	✓	✓
Nations	England	England	England	England
Years	1802-1864	1802-1864	1802-1864	1802-1864
Obsv	8038	8038	8033	8033
Mean of DV (weighted)	0.30	0.30	0.37	0.37
SD of DV (weighted)	0.46	0.46	0.60	0.60

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: OLS regressions. Standard errors robust to clustering parishes together that share a unique representational history. The unit of analysis is the aggregated parish unit (see Section 4). Observations are weighted by the number of constituent parishes represented by each aggregated geographic unit. Contests are measured on the extensive margin if there were more candidates running than seats available in the main (e.g., first) return for the parliament. That is, by elections are excluded. The number of challengers is measured as the number of candidates in excess of the number of seats available. Therefore, zero challengers is an uncontested election. The excluded category is parishes that were part of the same constituency before and after 1832 and thus their changes in population per MP are due only to population growth, not due to boundary changes. The excluded category consists of parishes experiencing no meaningful change in representation. These are parishes whose population per MP changed by less than 5% between the pre- and post-reform representative environments. The 5% threshold is intended to distinguish substantively meaningful changes in representation from minor fluctuations arising from population growth or the construction of historical geographic boundaries. Less than 1% of parish observations associated with extremely small reconstructed constituency populations, and therefore implausibly large values of population per MP, are excluded from the analysis.

G Geographic and Franchise Reform

Geographic and franchise reform were formally distinct components of the Great Reform Act, but their consequences were jointly determined. A common franchise qualification could produce very different electorates depending upon which populations were placed inside the constituency to which it applied. This interaction was particularly important among surviving boroughs, where reformers could preserve the existing constituency while altering the territory incorporated within it.

I examine this relationship among pre-reform English boroughs that survived into the first post-reform parliament. I distinguish boroughs experiencing no major boundary change from those enlarged into surrounding parishes and those enlarged to encompass the “modern town.” The latter two reforms altered the populations to which the new borough franchise applied in quite different ways.

Descriptively, the resulting electorates differ considerably across these forms of geographic reform. Boroughs experiencing no major boundary change contained approximately 115 electors per 1,000 residents after reform. The corresponding figure was approximately 71 among boroughs enlarged into surrounding parishes and 203 among boroughs enlarged to the modern town. These differences do not simply reflect the total population incorporated within the constituency. In regressions conditioning on logged constituency population and region, parish-enlarged boroughs have substantially smaller electorates than otherwise comparable unchanged boroughs, while modern-town extensions have larger electorates.

Table G1: Geographic reform and the post-reform electorate

	ln(Electors)	ln(Electors/Population)
	(1)	(2)
Parish extension	-0.39** (0.15)	-0.39** (0.15)
Modern-town extension	0.32* (0.17)	0.32* (0.17)
ln(Population)	0.63*** (0.068)	-0.37*** (0.068)
Region FE	✓	✓
Nations	England	England
Years	1833	1833
Obsv	145	145
Mean of DV	6.53	-2.43
SD of DV	1.01	0.81
R-squared	0.621	0.400

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: OLS regressions with robust standard errors. The sample consists of surviving pre-reform English boroughs observed in the first post-reform parliament. The omitted category is boroughs experiencing no major boundary change.

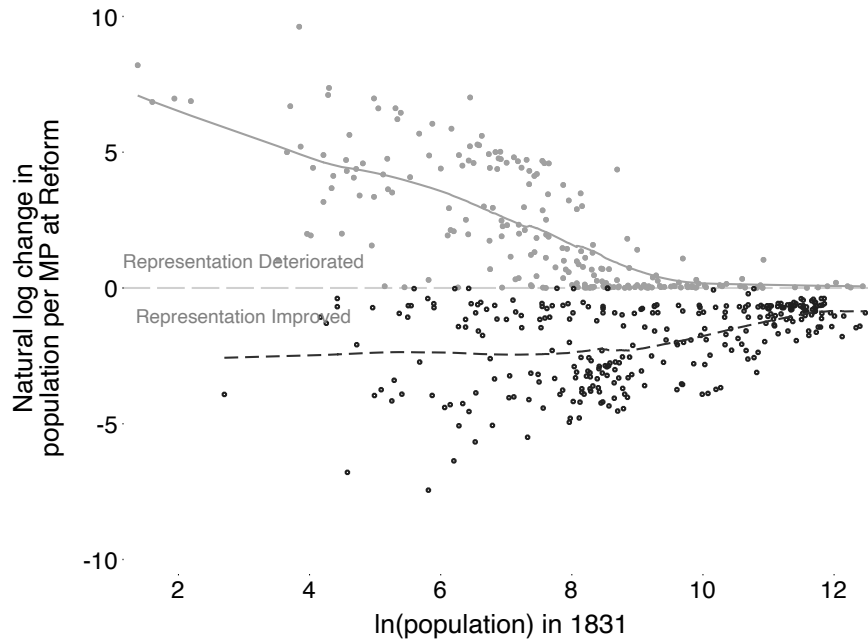
The pattern reinforces the reason for not treating the post-reform electorate as a pre-determined control in the main analysis. Geographic reform did not merely determine which territory an MP represented. By determining which populations were placed inside

the boundaries of the new franchise rules, it also helped construct the electorate that subsequently participated in the reformed constituency.

H Population and the Magnitude of Representational Reallocation

The main analysis estimates the relationship between pre-reform population and representational reallocation using linear specifications separately for places whose representation improved and deteriorated. Figure H1 shows the same relationship nonparametrically. The figure plots the change in population represented per MP against population in 1831 and fits separate Lowess curves on either side of zero.

Figure H1: Population and the magnitude of representational reallocation



Notes: The figure relates logged population in 1831 to the log change in population represented per MP between the pre- and post-reform representative environments. Negative values indicate improved representation and positive values indicate deteriorated representation. Points represent the stable geographic units described in Section 4. Separate Lowess curves are estimated for places experiencing improvements and deteriorations. The figure is descriptive and is intended to show the functional form underlying the corresponding linear estimates in Table 3.